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Lamentations

Lamentations - Introduction

Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of Lamentations

1. First poem: Lament over the desolation of Jerusalem (1:1–22)
2. Second poem: Yahweh has punished Zion (2:1–22)
3. Third poem: Suffering and hope in Yahweh's faithfulness (3:1–66)
4. Fourth poem: The destruction of Jerusalem's people and leaders (4:1–22)
5. Fifth poem: A communal prayer for restoration (5:1–22)

What is the book of Lamentations about?

The Babylonians destroyed Jerusalem in 586 B.C., burned the temple, and took most of the people into exile. Lamentations is a collection of five poems responding to this catastrophe. The poems express deep grief over the loss of the city and its people, confess that the destruction came as divine judgment for sin, and close with a prayer for Yahweh to restore his people. Central to the book is the declaration in chapter 3 that Yahweh's covenant faithfulness never ends.

Who wrote the book of Lamentations?

The book does not name its author. The traditional view, held by Jewish and early Christian interpreters, is that the prophet Jeremiah wrote it. The writer appears to have been an eyewitness to the fall of Jerusalem, and the tone of mourning resembles portions of the book of Jeremiah. However, the book itself does not make this claim. Translators may follow the traditional attribution or leave the authorship unspecified.

How should the title of this book be translated?

This book is traditionally called "Lamentations." Translators may use a descriptive title such as "Poems of Grief" or "Songs of Mourning." If translators follow the tradition that Jeremiah wrote it, a title like "The Laments of Jeremiah" is also possible.

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

Did God abandon his people?

The poems often describe Yahweh as having rejected or abandoned Jerusalem. This is part of the honest expression of suffering under divine judgment, not a final theological conclusion. The author also affirms that Yahweh's covenant faithfulness never ends and is renewed each morning (3:22–23). Unlike the gods of other ancient Near Eastern nations, who were thought to abandon their cities because they were too weak to protect them, Yahweh abandoned Jerusalem because his people sinned against him.

What is a lament?

A lament is a poem or song of grief and mourning. In the ancient Near East, people composed laments after the destruction of cities. The five poems in Lamentations are in this tradition, but they address Yahweh directly, confess sin, and express hope for restoration. Some scholars think the slow heavy rhythm of the Hebrew verse in this book reflects the weight of mourning.

Part 3: Important Translation Issues

The acrostic structure

Four of the five poems in Lamentations use an acrostic pattern based on the Hebrew alphabet of 22 letters. In chapters 1, 2, and 4 each verse begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In chapter 3, groups of three consecutive verses share each letter, creating 66 verses in total. Chapter 5 has 22 verses matching the alphabet count but does not follow alphabetic order. This structure cannot be reproduced in most languages. Translators do not need to create an equivalent; a brief explanatory note may help readers appreciate the literary craftsmanship of the original.

The personification of Jerusalem as a woman

Throughout Lamentations, the city of Jerusalem is addressed and described as a woman — a widow, a grieving mother, a disgraced princess. Neighboring nations are addressed the same way (for example, "the daughter of Edom" in 4:21). This literary technique helps readers feel the personal anguish of destruction. Translators should use feminine pronouns consistently when the text addresses the city in this way.

"let" and "may"

The ULT uses the English helping verbs "let" and "may" to show that a speaker is expressing a desire that something happen or that someone do something. It uses the verb "let" for more assertive expressions, and it uses the verb "may" for more deferential expressions. For example, when Jeremiah says in 3:28, "Let him sit alone and be silent," he means "I want him to sit alone and be silent." Languages that do not have a volitional form might say "He ought to sit alone and be silent," or they might use an imperative, "Sit alone and be silent!" Translate this volitional form in the most natural way in your language to indicate that the

speaker is expressing what he wants someone to do or what he wishes someone would do.

Lamentations - Chapter 1 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a lament over the destruction of Jerusalem and the exile of Judah's people to Babylon. The narrator and personified Jerusalem alternate as speakers, mourning her desolation.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Jerusalem personified as a woman

Throughout this chapter, Jerusalem is addressed as a woman — a widow, a princess, a grieving mother. Translators should use feminine pronouns consistently for the city.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Acrostic structure

Each of the 22 verses begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Most languages cannot reproduce this pattern; a brief footnote may inform readers of this literary feature.

Lamentations 1:1 (#1)

אֵיכָכָה ׀ יָשְׁבָה בָדָד הָעִיר רַבָּתִי עָם

"How & alone, the city that was great with people"

The author is speaking of the city of Jerusalem as if it were a woman who could **sit alone** in mourning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See the Introduction to Lamentations for further discussion of the term and how to translate it here and throughout this book. Alternate translation: [How the city that was great with people is now deserted]

See: Personification

Lamentations 1:1 (#2)

הָיְתָה כְּאַלְמָנָה רַבָּתִי בַגּוֹיִם

"She has become & who was great among the nations"

The point of this comparison is that just as **a widow** is alone, unprotected, and grieving, so is Jerusalem now without allies or support. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [She has become alone and unprotected, though she was once great among the nations]

See: Simile

Lamentations 1:1 (#3)

שָׂרָתִי בַּמְּדִינוֹת הָיְתָה לָמַס

"has become a forced laborer"

Here the author is speaking as if Jerusalem were a **princess** who has been reduced to slavery. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The city that once ruled over the provinces now serves them]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:2 (#1)

בָּכוֹ תִבְכֶּה בַּלַּיְלָה וְדִמְעָתָהּ עַל לֶחֱיָהּ

"and her tears are on her cheeks"

The author is speaking of the city of Jerusalem as if it were a woman who **weeps** and has **tears on her cheeks**. See the note on verse one. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The people of Jerusalem weep bitterly in the night, and their tears are on their cheeks]

See: Personification

Lamentations 1:2 (#2)

כָּל־רֵעֶיהָ בָּגְדוּ בָהּ הָיוּ לָהּ לְאוֹיְבִים

"her companions have betrayed her; they have become enemies to her"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [All her companions have betrayed her; yes, they have become her enemies]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 1:3 (#1)

מֵעֹנִי וּמֵרֹב עֲבֹדָה

"from affliction and from the greatness of forced labor"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **affliction** and **greatness**, you could express

the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [where she suffers greatly under forced labor]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:3 (#2)

לֹא מָצְאָה מָנוֹחַ

“she has not found a resting place”

The author is speaking of having a secure and peaceful home as if it were a **resting place** that Judah could find. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [she finds no safe place to rest] or [she has found no peace and security]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:3 (#3)

בֵּבֵין הַמְּצָרִים

“between the narrow passes”

Here the author is speaking as if being trapped with no escape were being caught **between the narrow passes** of a mountain gorge. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in a place where they were trapped]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:4 (#1)

דַּרְכֵי צִיּוֹן אֲבֵלוֹת

“of Zion are mourning”

The author is speaking of **the roads of Zion** as if they were a person who could mourn. He means that the roads are empty and unused. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The roads of Zion are empty and unused]

See: Personification

Lamentations 1:5 (#1)

הָיוּ צָרֶיהָ לְרֹאשׁ אוֹיְבֶיהָ שָׁלְווּ

“Her adversaries have become the head; her enemies”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Her adversaries have become the head and are prospering]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 1:5 (#2)

עַל רֹב־פְּשָׁעֶיהָ

“over the greatness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **greatness** and **transgressions**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because she transgressed so greatly against him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:5 (#3)

עוֹלָלֶיהָ הָלְכוּ שְׁבִי לִפְנֵי־צָר

“Her children have gone away & before the adversary”

The expression **Her children have gone away as captives** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the adversary. Alternate translation: [The adversary has taken her children away as captives]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 1:6 (#1)

מִן־בַּת־צִיּוֹן

“from the daughter of Zion”

The author is speaking of Jerusalem and its people as if the city were a **daughter**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from Jerusalem] or [from the people of Zion]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:6 (#2)

כָּל־הֲדָרָהּ

“her majesty has departed”

Here the author is speaking as if Jerusalem's **majesty** were a person or thing that could depart from her. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all her honor has been lost]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:6 (#3)

כָּל־הֲדָרָהּ

"her majesty has departed"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **majesty**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [everything that made her majestic is gone]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:6 (#4)

הָיוּ שָׂרֶיהָ כְּאַיָּלִים לֹא־מָצְאוּ מִרְעֶה

"have become & that have found no pasture"

The point of this comparison is that just as **deer that have found no pasture** are weak and helpless, so are **Her princes** without strength or resources. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Her princes have become weak and helpless, like deer that have found no pasture]

See: Simile

Lamentations 1:6 (#5)

בְּלֹא־כֹחַ

"without strength"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being completely weak]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:7 (#1)

יְמֵי עָנְיָהּ וּמְרוּדֶיהָ

"in the days of her affliction and of her wanderings"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **affliction** and **wanderings**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [in the days when she was afflicted and displaced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:7 (#2)

בִּנְפֹּל עַמָּהּ בְּיַד־צָר

"of the adversary"

The author is using **fell into the hand of** as a common expression of the culture to mean "came under the power of." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When her people came under the power of the adversary]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 1:8 (#1)

לְנִידָּה הָיְתָה

"she has become an abhorrence"

Here the author is speaking as if Jerusalem were an object of ritual **abhorrence**, something that people treat as defiling and avoid. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [she has become something people avoid]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:8 (#2)

עֶרְוָתָהּ

"her nakedness"

By **her nakedness**, the author means her naked body is being exposed to shame before her enemies. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [how shamefully exposed she is]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 1:8 (#3)

וַתָּשָׁב אָחוֹר

"backward"

Turning backward was a symbolic action by which Jerusalem showed her shame and disgrace before those who saw her. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and retreated in shame]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 1:9 (#1)

טֻמְאָתָהּ בְּשׁוּלֶ֫יהָ

“Her uncleanness is in her skirts”

The author is referring to menstrual impurity in a polite way by using the phrase **Her uncleanness is in her skirts**. He uses this image to characterize Jerusalem’s profound defilement before God. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [She is as unclean as a woman in her menstrual impurity] or [She is deeply defiled by her sin]

See: Euphemism

Lamentations 1:9 (#2)

טֻמְאָתָהּ

“Her uncleanness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **uncleanness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The way she has made herself impure]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:9 (#3)

אַחֲרִיתָ֫הּ

“her end”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **her end**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what would happen to her as a result]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:9 (#4)

וַתֵּ֥רֶד פְּלָאִ֑ים

“And she went down astonishingly”

The author is speaking of Jerusalem’s ruin as if she were going **down** to a lower place. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And she was brought to ruin in an astonishing way]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:9 (#5)

הִגְדִּ֥יל אוֹיֵ֖ב

“the enemy has magnified himself”

The word **himself** indicates that the object of the verb is the same as the subject of the verb. Use a way that is natural in your language to indicate that the enemy is the one doing the action to himself. Alternate translation: [the enemy has boasted greatly]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

Lamentations 1:10 (#1)

יָדוֹ֙ פָּ֣רַשׂ צָ֔ר עַ֖ל כָּל־מַחֲמַדֶּ֑יהָ

“The adversary & his hand over”

The author is using **spread out his hand over** as a common expression of the culture to mean “seized and took possession of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The adversary has seized all her precious things]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 1:11 (#1)

מְבַקְּשִׁ֥ים לֶ֖חֶם

“seeking bread”

The author is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [seeking food]

See: Synecdoche

Lamentations 1:11 (#2)

לְהָשִׁ֥יב נֶ֖פֶשׁ

“to restore life”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **life**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to keep themselves alive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:11 (#3)

רְאֵ֤ה יְהוָה֙ וְהַבִּ֣יטָה כִּֽי־הָיִ֥יתִי זוֹלֵ֖לָה

“See, Yahweh, and look, for I have become despised”

It would be good to present this as a direct quotation, if possible, to show that the city of Jerusalem is speaking to Yahweh.

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 1:12 (#1)

לֹ֣וא אֲלֵיכֶ֔ם כָּל־עֹבְרֵ֖י דָּ֑רֶךְ

“Is it nothing to you, all you who pass along the way”

Jerusalem is speaking to **all you who pass along the way**, people who are not in conversation with her. She is doing this to communicate to the people listening to her that she feels very strongly about her suffering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if she were speaking directly to the people about the passers–by. It would be good to present verse12 through verse16 as a direct quotation, if possible, to show that Jerusalem is speaking to the people. Alternate translation: [Is it nothing to all those who pass along the way]

See: Apostrophe

Lamentations 1:12 (#2)

לֹ֣וא אֲלֵיכֶ֔ם כָּל־עֹבְרֵ֖י דָּ֑רֶךְ

“Is it nothing to you, all you who pass along the way”

Jerusalem is using the question form to emphasize that the passers–by should pay attention to its suffering and that no one has ever suffered as it has. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this question as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You who pass along the way should care deeply about what has happened to me.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 1:12 (#3)

בְּי֖וֹם חֲר֥וֹן אַפּֽוֹ

“on the day of his burning anger”

The speaker is using **the day of his burning anger** as a common expression of the culture to mean the time when Yahweh expressed his fierce anger in judgment. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the time when he was fiercely angry]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 1:13 (#1)

מִמָּר֣וֹם שָׁלַ֤ח־אֵשׁ֙ בְּעַצְמֹתַ֔י וַיִּרְדֶּ֖נָּה

“fire”

Jerusalem is speaking as if God’s judgment were **fire** that **he sent** from heaven into her **bones** and that **ruled over them**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From on high he sent suffering deep inside me, and it overwhelmed me]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:13 (#2)

פָּרַ֤שׂ רֶ֙שֶׁת֙ לְרַגְלַ֔י הֱשִׁיבַ֖נִי אָח֑וֹר

“for my feet & back”

Here Jerusalem is speaking as if God were a hunter who **spread a net** to catch prey and **turned** her **back** so she could not escape. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He trapped me and kept me from going forward]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:14 (#1)

נִשְׂקַ֤ד עֹ֙ל פְּשָׁעַ֔י בְּיָד֖וֹ יִשְׂתָּרְגוּ֙ עָל֣וּ עַל־צַוָּארִ֔י

“The yoke of my transgressions was bound fast, they are intertwined by his hand; they have come up onto my neck”

Here Jerusalem is speaking as if her sins were **a yoke** that was **bound fast** and **intertwined** and placed on her **neck**, like the wooden frame placed on the neck of a draft animal to control it. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My sins have completely overpowered me] or [Yahweh has made my sins control me completely]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:14 (#2)

נִשְׂקַ֤ד עֹ֙ל פְּשָׁעַ֔י

“The yoke of my transgressions was bound fast”

The expression **The yoke of my transgressions was bound fast** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [He bound fast the yoke of my transgressions]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 1:14 (#3)

פְּשָׁעַי

“of my transgressions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgressions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of the ways I transgressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:14 (#4)

כֹּחִי

“my strength to stumble”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [me to become weak]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:15 (#1)

גָּפַת דָּרַךְ אֲדֹנָי לִבְתוּלַת בַּת־יְהוּדָה

“The Lord & for the virgin & of Judah”

Here Jerusalem is speaking as if the Lord were a person who has **trodden the winepress**, crushing grapes underfoot. She means that the Lord has crushed the people of Judah in judgment. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [The Lord has crushed the virgin daughter of Judah like grapes in a winepress]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:15 (#2)

לִבְתוּלַת בַּת־יְהוּדָה

“for the virgin & of Judah”

Jerusalem is speaking of the people of Judah as if they were a **virgin daughter**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for the people of Judah]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:16 (#1)

אֲנִי בוֹכִיָּה עֵינִי ׀ עֵינִי יֹרְדָה מַּיִם

“I, I am weeping; my eye, my eye is running down with water”

The repetition of the phrases, **I, I am weeping** and **my eye, my eye** is an emphatic form. Jerusalem is using the repetition for emphasis to express the intensity of her weeping. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I am weeping; my eye is continually running down with water]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 1:16 (#2)

עֵינִי ׀ עֵינִי יֹרְדָה מַּיִם

“my eye, my eye is running down with water”

Here Jerusalem is speaking as if her **eye** were a stream of water **running down**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my tears are flowing constantly]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:16 (#3)

מְנַחֵם

“a comforter”

Jerusalem is not referring to a specific **comforter**. She means anyone in general who could comfort. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone to comfort me]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Lamentations 1:16 (#4)

מֵשִׁיב נַפְשִׁי

“who restores my life”

Jerusalem is speaking of her **life** as if it were something that could be restored and given back to her. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who could revive my strength]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:17 (#1)

פָּרְשָׂה צִיּוֹן בְּיָדֶיהָ

“Zion has spread out her hands”

The author is speaking of **Zion** as if it were a woman who could **spread out her hands** in a gesture of pleading. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The people of Zion plead for help]

See: Personification

Lamentations 1:17 (#2)

הָיְתָה יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם לְנִדָּה בֵּינֵיהֶם

“Jerusalem has become an abhorrence among them”

Here the author is speaking as if Jerusalem were an object of ritual **abhorrence**, something that the surrounding nations treat as defiling and avoid. See the note on verse 8. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Jerusalem has become something all the surrounding nations consider filthy]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:18 (#1)

צַדִּיק הוּא יְהוָה כִּי פִיהוּ מָרִיתִי

“Yahweh {is} righteous, for I have rebelled against his mouth”

It would be good to present verse18 through verse22 as a direct quotation, if possible, to show that the city of Jerusalem is speaking. In [verses18–19], Jerusalem speaks to passers–by, and in [20–22] she speaks directly to Yahweh.

See: Personification

Lamentations 1:18 (#2)

כִּי פִיהוּ מָרִיתִי

“for I have rebelled against his mouth”

Here, **his mouth** represents his commands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for I have rebelled against his commands]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 1:18 (#3)

כָּל־עמים

“all peoples”

Jerusalem is speaking to **all peoples**. She is doing this to communicate to the people listening that she feels very strongly about her suffering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if she were speaking directly to the people as in the UST.

See: Apostrophe

Lamentations 1:19 (#1)

הֵ֣מָּה רִמּ֔וּנִי

“deceived me”

The repetition of the pronoun **they, they** is an emphatic form. Jerusalem is using the repetition for emphasis to express the depth of betrayal. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [they completely deceived me]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 1:19 (#2)

גָּוְע֥וּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: גָּוְע֥וּ”

Jerusalem is referring to death in a polite way by using the word **expired**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [passed away] or [died]

See: Euphemism

Lamentations 1:20 (#1)

רְאֵ֣ה יְהוָ֔ה כִּי־צַ֖ר־לִ֑י

“See, Yahweh, for I am in distress”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Jerusalem is urgently appealing to Yahweh to observe her suffering. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [Please see, Yahweh, that I am in distress]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 1:20 (#2)

מֵעַ֣י חֳמַרְמָ֔רוּ

“my inward parts are churning”

Here, **my inward parts** represent deep emotions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I am deeply distressed]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 1:20 (#3)

נֶהְפַּ֤ךְ לִבִּי֙ בְּקִרְבִּ֔י

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נֶהְפַּךְ לִבִּי֙ בְּקִרְבִּ֔י”

Here Jerusalem is speaking as if her **heart** had been physically **overturned within** her. She means that she is in complete emotional anguish. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am in total anguish within myself]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 1:20 (#4)

נֶהְפַּךְ לִבִּי֙ בְּקִרְבִּ֔י

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נֶהְפַּךְ לִבִּי֙ בְּקִרְבִּ֔י”

The expression **my heart has been overturned** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God has overturned my heart within me]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 1:20 (#5)

מִח֣וּץ שִׁכְלָ֔ה־חֶ֖רֶב בַּבָּ֑יִת כַּמָּ֖וֶת

“Outside the sword”

Jerusalem is referring to all of the destruction by naming two extremes, **Outside** and **inside**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Everywhere there is death, both outside in the streets and inside the buildings]

See: Merism

Lamentations 1:21 (#1)

אֵ֥ין מְנַחֵ֖ם לִֽי

“there is no comforter for me”

Jerusalem is not referring to a specific **comforter**. She means, in a general sense, someone who is willing or able to comfort her. See how you translated the same word in verse16. Alternate translation: [there is no one able to comfort me] or [there is no one willing to comfort me]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Lamentations 1:21 (#2)

רָעָתִ֑י

“my calamity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **calamity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the tragic events that we have experienced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 1:21 (#3)

וְיִהְי֖וּ כָּמ֥וֹנִי

“and let them be like me”

When Jerusalem says **and let them be like me**, she is saying what she wants God to do. Alternate translation: [and I desire that our enemies will suffer as we have] or [and God, you should require our enemies to experience the same]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Lamentations 1:22 (#1)

פִּשְׁעָ֑י

“my transgressions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgressions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wrong actions I have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Lamentations 2 is a 22–verse acrostic poem; each verse begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. The poet portrays Yahweh himself as a warrior and enemy who has brought destruction on Jerusalem and her people.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Lament

The daughter of Zion

The phrase “daughter of Zion” is an idiom, a common expression in the original language for referring to a city and its inhabitants. Translators should render this in a way that is clear and natural in their language.

The footstool of God

The temple in Jerusalem was spoken of as the footstool of God, the place where his presence rested on earth. This image makes the destruction of the temple especially shocking.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Acrostic structure
Each verse begins with a successive Hebrew letter (aleph through taw). Most languages cannot reproduce this pattern; a brief note explaining the acrostic to readers is sufficient.

Lamentations 2:1 (#1)

אֵיכָהּ֩ יָעִ֨יב בְּאַפּ֜וֹ ׀ אֲדֹנָ֗י אֶת־בַּת־צִיּ֙וֹן֙

“How the Lord has covered with a cloud the daughter of Zion in his nose”

The exclamation **How** indicates that Jeremiah is expressing his grief and sorrow over what the Lord has done to Jerusalem. Your language may have its own way of expressing feelings of grief and sorrow. Alternate translation: [The Lord has covered with a cloud in his anger the daughter of Zion]

See: Exclamations

Lamentations 2:1 (#2)

יָעִ֨יב

“has covered with a cloud”

The writer is speaking of the Lord bringing judgment on Jerusalem as if the Lord **covered with a cloud** the city, that is, as if he brought darkness and gloom upon it. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has darkened]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:1 (#3)

בְּאַפּ֜וֹ

“in his nose”

The writer is using the phrase **in his nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean that the Lord is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in his wrath]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:1 (#4)

אֶת־בַּת־צִיּ֙וֹן֙

“the daughter of Zion”

The writer is speaking of the people of Jerusalem as if they were a **daughter** of the city. This is a common expression in the original language for referring to a city and its inhabitants. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly here and elsewhere in this lament. See the Lamentations 2 Introduction for more information. Alternate translation: [the people of Jerusalem]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:1 (#5)

הִשְׁלִ֤יךְ מִשָּׁמַ֙יִם֙ אֶ֣רֶץ תִּפְאֶ֔רֶת יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“He has cast from heaven to earth the splendor of Israel”

The writer is speaking of the Lord removing Israel’s honor as if the Lord had **cast down from heaven to earth the splendor of Israel**. The image of heaven represents a high and honored position, while earth represents a low and disgraced position. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has taken away the honor of Israel and made it a disgrace]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:1 (#6)

תִּפְאֶ֔רֶת יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“the splendor of Israel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [everything that made Israel splendid]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:1 (#7)

הֲדֹם־רַגְלָ֑יו

“the footstool of his feet”

Here, **the footstool of his feet** represents the temple in Jerusalem, since the temple was considered the place where God’s presence rested on earth, as a king rests his feet on a footstool. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his temple]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:1 (#8)

הֲדֹם־רַגְלָ֑יו

“the footstool of his feet”

The writer is using the possessive form to describe a **footstool** that belongs to God, that is, the place where God rests his feet. This refers to the temple or the ark of the covenant. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express the idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the footstool where he rests his feet]

See: Possession

Lamentations 2:1 (#9)

בְּיוֹם אַפּוֹ

“on the day of his nose”

Here, **on the day of his nose** represents the time or occasion when God acted in judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on the occasion of his wrath]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:2 (#1)

בִּלַּע אֲדֹנָי

“The Lord has swallowed up”

The writer is speaking of the Lord completely destroying the settlements of Jacob as if the Lord has **swallowed** them **up**, as a person might consume food. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The Lord has completely destroyed]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:2 (#2)

אֵת כָּל־נְאוֹת יַעֲקֹב

“all the pastures of Jacob”

Here, **all the pastures of Jacob** represents the dwelling places of the people of Israel, since pastures were the places where people lived and kept their flocks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the dwelling places of the descendants of Jacob]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:2 (#3)

בְּעֶבְרָתוֹ

“in his wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [very angrily]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:2 (#4)

הִגִּיעַ לָאָרֶץ

“he has brought {them} to the ground”

The writer is speaking of the Lord destroying the fortifications as if **he has brought them to the ground**, that is, knocked them flat. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has completely destroyed them]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:2 (#5)

חִלֵּל מַמְלָכָה וְשָׂרֶיהָ

“He has profaned the kingdom and her princes”

The writer is speaking of the Lord stripping the kingdom and its rulers of their honor and dignity as if they were sacred things that the Lord had made common and unclean. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has dishonored the kingdom and its princes]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:3 (#1)

גָּדַע בָּחֳרִי אַף כֹּל קֶרֶן יִשְׂרָאֵל

“He has cut off in the burning of nose every horn of Israel”

The writer is speaking of God removing the power of Israel as if God **cut off** every **horn**, since a horn represents the strength and power of an animal. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has destroyed in fierce anger all the power of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:3 (#2)

בָּחֳרִי אַף

“in the burning of nose”

Here, **nose** represents the emotion of wrath, since the nostrils flare when a person is angry. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a compa-

rable expression that has the same meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in burning wrath] or [angrily]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:3 (#3)

הֵשִׁ֤יב אָחוֹר֙ יְמִינ֔וֹ

“He has turned back his right hand”

Here, **his right hand** represents God’s power to help and protect his people, since the right hand was associated with strength and action. The writer says that God **turned back** this power, meaning he withdrew his protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has withdrawn his protective power]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:3 (#4)

מִפְּנֵ֥י אוֹיֵ֖ב

“from the face of the enemy”

Jeremiah is using **from the face of** as a common expression to mean “from before” or “away from the direction of.” He means that God withdrew his right hand away from facing the enemy, leaving Israel unprotected. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from before the enemy] or [from the enemy’s advance]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:3 (#5)

וַיִּבְעַ֤ר בְּיַעֲקֹב֙ כְּאֵ֣שׁ לֶהָבָ֔ה

“and he burned in Jacob like a fire of flame”

The writer uses this comparison to say that God’s judgment was as destructive to Israel as **a fire of flame** is to whatever it burns. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he has destroyed Jacob with devastating force]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:3 (#6)

אָכְלָ֖ה סָבִֽיב

“consuming all around”

The writer is continuing the image of fire, speaking of God’s judgment as a flame that destroys everything in its path. The word **consuming** pictures the fire burning to nothing everything it touches. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [destroying everything on every side]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:4 (#1)

דָּרַ֤ךְ קַשְׁתּוֹ֙ כְּאוֹיֵ֔ב נִצָּ֖ב יְמִינ֑וֹ כְּצָ֔ר

“He has bent his bow like an enemy; his right hand is stationed like an adversary”

The writer uses comparisons to describe God’s hostility toward his own people. He says that God **has bent his bow like an enemy; his right hand is stationed like an adversary**, meaning that God has prepared to attack his people the way an enemy would and has taken the stance of one ready to fight against them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [He has prepared to attack us as an enemy would; he has positioned himself to fight against us like an adversary]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:4 (#2)

יְמִינ֑וֹ

“his right hand”

Here, **his right hand** represents God’s power and ability to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his power]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:4 (#3)

כֹּ֖ל מַחֲמַדֵּי־עָ֑יִן

“all the delights of the eye”

Here, **the eye** represents sight and what is pleasing to behold. The phrase **the delights of the eye** refers to everything people treasured and found beautiful. Some understand this as referring specifically to the fine young men of Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everything they treasured] or [all the finest young men]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:4 (#4)

בְּאֹהֶל֙ בַּת־צִיּ֔וֹן

“In the tent of the daughter of Zion”

The writer speaks of Zion as if it were a woman, calling it **the daughter of Zion**, and he describes the city as her **tent** or dwelling place. For more information, see the Lamentations 2 Introduction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea in another way here and in verse 18. Alternate translation: [In the city of Jerusalem]

See: Personification

Lamentations 2:4 (#5)

שָׁפַ֤ךְ כָּאֵשׁ֙ חֲמָת֔וֹ

“he has poured out his anger like fire”

The writer uses a comparison to describe God’s anger. He says that God **has poured out his anger like fire**, meaning that God’s anger has been destructive and consuming. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his anger has been as destructive as fire]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:4 (#6)

שָׁפַ֤ךְ כָּאֵשׁ֙ חֲמָת֔וֹ

“he has poured out his anger like fire”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **anger**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he has shown how angry he is by burning like fire]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:5 (#1)

הָיָ֤ה אֲדֹנָי֙ ׀ כְּאוֹיֵ֔ב

“The Lord has become like an enemy”

The writer uses a comparison to describe how God has treated his own people. He says that **The Lord has become like an enemy**, meaning that God has acted against his people as an enemy would. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [The Lord has acted as though he were an enemy]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:5 (#2)

בִּלַּ֤ע יִשְׂרָאֵל֙ בִּלַּ֣ע כָּל־אַרְמְנוֹתֶ֔יהָ שִׁחֵ֖ת מִבְצָרֶ֑יו

“he has swallowed up Israel. He has swallowed up all her citadels; he has destroyed his fortifications”

These three phrases mean basically the same thing. Each one emphasizes the totality of God’s destruction by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with words that show that the second and third phrases are repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in Lamentations, and follow that approach here and throughout this chapter. Alternate translation: [He has utterly destroyed Israel, all her citadels, and all his fortifications]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 2:5 (#3)

בִּלַּ֤ע יִשְׂרָאֵל֙

“he has swallowed up Israel”

The writer is speaking of God’s destruction of Israel as if God had **swallowed** the nation like a beast consuming its prey. This emphasizes the completeness of the destruction. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has completely destroyed Israel]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:5 (#4)

תַּאֲנִיָּ֖ה וַאֲנִיָּֽה

“mourning and groaning”

The terms **mourning** and **groaning** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [great grief]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:5 (#5)

תַּאֲנִיָּ֖ה וַאֲנִיָּֽה

“mourning and groaning”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **mourning** and **groaning**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [and caused people to mourn and lament greatly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:6 (#1)

וַיַּחְמֹס כַּגָּן שֻׂכֹּו

“And he has done violence like {to} his garden booth”

The writer is comparing God’s destruction of his sanctuary to the tearing down of **his garden booth**, a temporary seasonal shelter. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [He violently tore down his sanctuary as if it were a temporary shelter]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:6 (#2)

מוֹעֵד וְשַׁבָּת

“appointed festival and Sabbath”

The writer is referring to all of Israel’s sacred worship occasions by naming two major components, **appointed festival** and **Sabbath**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all their sacred worship occasions]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:6 (#3)

בְּזַעַם־אַפּוֹ

“in the indignation of his nose”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **indignation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because he was indignantly angry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:6 (#4)

מֶלֶךְ וְכֹהֵן

“king and priest”

The writer is referring to all of Israel’s leadership by naming two major components, **king** and **priest**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all their leaders]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:7 (#1)

מִזְבְּחוֹ

“his altar”

Here, **his altar** represents the entire sacrificial worship system of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelites’ worship] or [the place where people offered sacrifices to him]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:7 (#2)

הִסְגִּירַ בְּיַד־אוֹיֵב חוֹמֹת אַרְמְנוֹתֶיהָ

“He has delivered up into the hand of the enemy the walls of her palaces”

Here, **the hand of the enemy** represents the power and control of the enemy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He has given the walls of her palaces over to the enemy’s control]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:7 (#3)

קוֹל נָתְנוּ בְּבֵית־יְהוָה כְּיוֹם מוֹעֵד

“They raised a shout in the house of Yahweh as on the day of an appointed festival”

The writer compares the shouts of the enemies in the house of Yahweh to the shouts of worshipers on **an appointed festival** day. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [They shouted in the house of Yahweh the way worshipers used to shout on a festival day]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:8 (#1)

נָטָה קָו

“He stretched out the measuring line”

The writer is speaking of God’s careful planning for destruction as if God had **stretched out the measuring line** like a builder measuring before construction. However, God measured not to build but to tear down. If your language does not use this image, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He carefully planned the destruction]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:8 (#2)

לֹא־הֵשִׁיב יָדוֹ מִבַּלֵּעַ

“he did not turn back his hand from swallowing up”

The writer is speaking of God's destructive action as if God were **swallowing up** the city, consuming it completely. The phrase **his hand** represents God's active power. If your language does not use this image, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he did not hold back from completely destroying it]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:8 (#3)

וַיְאַבֵּל־חֵל וְחוֹמָה יַחְדָּו אֻמְלָלוּ

"And he caused the rampart and wall to mourn; together they have languished"

The writer speaks of **the rampart** and **wall** as if they were people who could **mourn** and languish. He says this because they lie in ruins. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he caused the rampart and wall to fall into ruins]

See: Personification

Lamentations 2:8 (#4)

חֵל וְחוֹמָה

"the rampart and wall"

The writer is referring to all of Jerusalem's defensive structures by naming two major components, **the rampart** and the **wall**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all of Jerusalem's defenses]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:9 (#1)

טָבְעוּ בָאָרֶץ שְׁעָרֶיהָ

"Her gates have sunk into the ground"

The writer is speaking of the complete destruction of **Her gates** as if they had **sunk into the ground**. If your language does not use this image, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Her gates have been completely destroyed]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:9 (#2)

אִבַּד וְשִׁבַּר בְּרִיחֶיהָ

"he has destroyed and shattered her bars"

The terms **destroyed** and **shattered** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [he has completely destroyed the bars of her gates]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:9 (#3)

אֵין תּוֹרָה

"there is no law"

Here, **law** represents the entire instruction and guidance of God. Without their land and temple, the people have no access to God's teaching. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [No one teaches them God's law]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:9 (#4)

גַּם־נְבִיאֶיהָ לֹא־מָצְאוּ חָזוֹן מֵיְהוָה

"Also, her prophets do not find a vision from Yahweh"

The writer is speaking of receiving **a vision from Yahweh** as if it were something that could be found through searching. He means that Yahweh has ceased communicating with the prophets. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Also, her prophets have received no vision from Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:10 (#1)

יֵשְׁבוּ לָאָרֶץ יִדְמוּ זִקְנֵי בַת־צִיּוֹן הֶעֱלוּ עָפָר עַל־רֹאשָׁם חָגְרוּ
שַׂקִּים הוֹרִידוּ לָאָרֶץ רֹאשָׁן בְּתוּלֹת יְרוּשָׁלָ͏ִם

"They sit on the ground; the elders of the daughter of Zion are silent. They have thrown up dust on their heads; they have put on sackcloth. The virgins of Jerusalem have bowed their heads to the ground"

Sitting on **the ground** in **silence**, throwing up **dust on their heads**, and putting **on sackcloth** (rough goat-hair cloth) were mourning customs expressing grief too deep for words. Bowing the head **to the ground** was a symbolic action expressing utter humiliation and grief. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [The elders of the daughter of Zion sit on the ground in silence to show that they are over-

whelmed with grief. They have thrown up dust on their heads; they have put on sackcloth. The virgins of Jerusalem bowed their heads to the ground to show their utter humiliation and grief]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 2:10 (#2)

יִדְּמוּ֩ זִקְנֵ֨י בַת־צִיּ֜וֹן יָשְׁב֣וּ לָאָ֗רֶץ דּוֹמ֔וּ עָל֖וּ עָפָ֣ר עַל־רֹאשָׁ֑ם חָגְר֥וּ שַׂקִּ֖ים הוֹרִ֣ידוּ לָאָ֔רֶץ רֹאשָׁ֥ן בְּתוּלֹ֖ת יְרוּשָׁלָֽ͏ִם

“the elders of the daughter of Zion are silent. They have thrown up dust on their heads; they have put on sackcloth. The virgins of Jerusalem have bowed their heads to the ground”

The writer is referring to all of the people of Jerusalem by naming two extremes, **the elders** (the oldest) and **The virgins** (the youngest women). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Everyone in Jerusalem, both old and young, has silently thrown dust on their heads and put on sackcloth and bowed their heads to the ground]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:11 (#1)

כָּלּ֤וּ בַדְּמָעוֹת֙ עֵינַ֔י

“My eyes have failed with tears”

The writer is using the expression **My eyes have failed with tears** as a common expression of the culture to mean that one has wept so much that the eyes are exhausted and can no longer produce tears. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have cried until my eyes are exhausted]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:11 (#2)

חֳמַרְמְרוּ֙ מֵעַ֔י

“my inner parts churn”

Here, **my inner parts** represent deep emotional anguish. Jeremiah uses the internal organs as a way of referring to intense grief. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I am deeply troubled within]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:11 (#3)

נִשְׁפַּ֤ךְ לָאָ֙רֶץ֙ כְּבֵדִ֔י

“My liver is poured out to the ground”

The writer is speaking of his emotional anguish as if his **liver** had been **poured out to the ground**, like liquid spilling from a container. He means that he is completely overwhelmed. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am completely overwhelmed with grief]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:11 (#4)

עוֹלֵ֖ל וְיוֹנֵ֑ק

“child and infant”

The terms **child** and **infant** are paired to represent the very youngest and most vulnerable members of the community. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express this with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the young children]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:12 (#1)

בְּהִתְעַטְּפָ֣ם כֶּחָלָ֔ל בִּרְחֹבֹ֖ת עִ֑יר

“when they faint like the slain in the streets of the city”

The writer compares the children to **the slain** collapsing in the streets, meaning the children fall as though they have been mortally wounded, but from hunger rather than the sword. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [when they collapse and die in the city streets]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:12 (#2)

בְּהִשְׁתַּפֵּ֥ךְ נַפְשָׁ֖ם אֶל־חֵ֣יק אִמּוֹתָֽם

“when their life is poured out in the lap of their mothers”

The writer is speaking of the children’s lives slowly draining away as if their souls were **poured out** like liquid from a container. He means that the children die slowly in their mothers’ arms. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [as they slowly die while their mothers hold them]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:13 (#1)

מָה־אָעִידֵךְ מָמָה אֲדַמֶּה־לָּךְ הַבַּתתֿ יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם מָמָה אַשְׁוֶה־לָּךְ וַאֲנַחֲמֵמֵךְ בְּתוּלַת בַּת־צִיּ֑וֹן

“What can I testify to you? To what can I compare you, O daughter of Jerusalem? To what can I liken you, that I may comfort you, O virgin daughter of Zion”

The writer uses a series of rhetorical questions to express the idea that he cannot find anything adequate to say about Jerusalem’s suffering, to express the idea that nothing compares to her suffering, and that no comparison is adequate to bring comfort. If you would not use rhetorical questions for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [I do not know what I could say to you. Nothing can be compared to your suffering, O daughter of Jerusalem. There is nothing I can say to bring you comfort, O virgin daughter of Zion.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 2:13 (#2)

כִּי־גָדוֹל כַּיָּ֖ם שִׁבְרֵ֑ךְ

“For your brokenness is as great as the sea”

The writer uses a comparison to describe Jerusalem’s destruction. He compares it to the greatness of **the sea**, meaning that the **brokenness** is immeasurable and overwhelming in its vastness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your destruction is as vast and deep as the ocean]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:13 (#3)

שִׁבְרֵ֑ךְ

“your brokenness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **brokenness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how broken you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:13 (#4)

מִ֣י יִרְפָּא־לָ֔ךְ

“who can heal you”

The writer uses another rhetorical question to express the idea that no one can remedy Jerusalem’s suffering. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [no one can heal you.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 2:14 (#1)

שָׁ֣וְא וְתָפֵ֔ל

“falsehood and worthlessness”

The terms **falsehood** and **worthlessness** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together to emphasize that what the prophets claimed to see had no truth or value. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [things that were completely misleading]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:14 (#2)

עֲוֹנֵ֑ךְ

“your iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ways you sinned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:14 (#3)

מַשְׂאֹ֥ות שָׁ֖וְא וּמַדּוּחִֽים

“oracles of falsehood and enticement”

The terms **falsehood** and **enticement** are paired to characterize the prophets’ deceptive messages as both untrue and misleadingly appealing. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express this with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [utterly false visions]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:15 (#1)

סָפְקוּ עָלַ֙יִךְ כַּפַּ֔יִם כֹּ֖ל

“clap {their} hands at you”

Clapping hands at someone was a symbolic action by which they showed scorn, mockery, and contempt. This

is not applause. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [mock you by clapping their hands]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 2:15 (#2)

שָׁרְקוּ֩ וַיָּנִ֨עוּ רֹאשָׁ֜ם

“They hiss and shake their heads”

Hissing and shaking the head were symbolic gestures of derision and scorn. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could add a short explanation. Alternate translation: [They express their contempt by hissing and shaking their heads]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 2:15 (#3)

הֲזֹ֣את הָעִ֗יר שֶׁיֹּאמְרוּ֙ כְּלִ֣ילַת יֹ֔פִי מָשׂ֖וֹשׂ לְכָל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“Is this the city that they called ‘the perfection of beauty, the joy of all the earth”

The passers-by use a rhetorical question to express their disbelief that the once-glorious city has fallen to such ruin. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [This cannot be the city that people used to call the most beautiful, the joy of the entire earth!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 2:15 (#4)

הֲזֹ֣את הָעִ֗יר שֶׁיֹּאמְרוּ֙ כְּלִ֣ילַת יֹ֔פִי מָשׂ֖וֹשׂ לְכָל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“Is this the city that they called ‘the perfection of beauty, the joy of all the earth”

This is a quotation within a quotation. The passers-by are quoting a title that others previously gave to Jerusalem. If your language does not allow quotations within quotations, you could express the inner quotation as indirect speech as in the UST.

See: Quotes within Quotes

Lamentations 2:15 (#5)

כְּלִ֣ילַת יֹ֔פִי מָשׂ֖וֹשׂ לְכָל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“the perfection of beauty, the joy of all the earth”

The expressions **the perfection of beauty** and **the joy of all the earth** are paired to express the former glory of Jerusalem. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express this with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the pride and joy of all the earth]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:16 (#1)

פָּצ֤וּ עָלַ֙יִךְ֙ פִּיהֶ֔ם

“have opened their mouths against you”

Opening the mouth wide against someone was a symbolic action by which someone showed hostility, scorn, and readiness to devour. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [mocked you openly]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 2:16 (#2)

שָׁרְקוּ֙ וַיַּחֲרְקוּ־שֵׁ֔ן

“They hiss and gnash {their} teeth”

Hissing and gnashing the teeth were symbolic gestures expressing hatred, rage, and contempt. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could add a short explanation.

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 2:16 (#3)

בְּלָ֖עְנוּ

“We have swallowed {her} up”

The enemies are speaking of their destruction of Jerusalem as if they had **swallowed her up** like an animal consuming its prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have completely destroyed her]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:16 (#4)

מָצָ֣אנוּ רָאִ֔ינוּ

“we have found it, we have seen it”

The expressions **we have found** and **we have seen** mean similar things. The enemies are using the two expressions together to express their satisfaction at finally witnessing the destruction they longed for. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [we have seen what we had been hoping to see]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 2:17 (#1)

חָמָ֖ל

“shown compassion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [spared them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:17 (#2)

הֵרִ֥ים קֶ֖רֶן צָרָֽיִךְ

“he has lifted up the horn of your adversaries”

The writer is speaking of God increasing the power of the enemies as if he had **lifted up** their **horn**, since a horn represents the strength of a powerful animal. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has made your enemies powerful]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 2:18 (#1)

חוֹמַ֣ת בַּת־צִיּ֔וֹן

“O wall of the daughter of Zion”

The writer speaks of the **wall of the daughter of Zion** as if it were a person who could weep. He says this because the wall lies in ruins and he urges it to mourn. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let the people of Zion cry out and weep]

See: Personification

Lamentations 2:18 (#2)

הוֹרִ֤ידִי כַנַּ֙חַל֙ דִּמְעָ֣ה יוֹמָ֔ם וָלָ֖יְלָה

“let tears flow down like a river day and night”

The writer uses a comparison to describe how abundant and continuous the weeping should be. He compares the flow of tears to **a river**, meaning the weeping should be constant and unceasing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Let your tears flow abundantly and continuously, day and night without stopping]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:18 (#3)

יוֹמָ֔ם וָלָ֖יְלָה

“day and night”

The writer is referring to all the time without stopping by naming two extremes, **day** and **night**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [continually without stopping]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:18 (#4)

בַּת־עֵינֵֽךְ

“the daughter of your eye”

The expression **the daughter of your eye** was a common expression meaning the pupil of the eye. In this context it means that one should not let the eyes stop weeping. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the pupil of your eye] or [your eyes]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:19 (#1)

לְרֹ֣אשׁ אַשְׁמֻר֔וֹת

“at the beginning of the night watches”

The writer assumes that his readers will know that the night watches were the periods into which the night was divided for keeping guard. You could say this explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [at the start of each period of the night]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 2:19 (#2)

שִׁפְכִ֤י כַמַּ֙יִם֙ לִבֵּ֔ךְ נֹ֖כַח פְּנֵ֣י אֲדֹנָ֑י

“Pour out your heart like water before the face of the Lord”

The writer uses a comparison to describe complete, unreserved prayer. He compares pouring out the heart to pouring out **water**, meaning one should hold nothing back and empty oneself completely before God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the comparison plainly. See how you translated the similar expressions in [2:4] and [2:11]. Alternate translation: [Open your heart completely to the Lord]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:19 (#3)

נֹכַח פְּנֵי אֲדֹנָי

“before the face of the Lord”

Here, **the face of the Lord** represents God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of the Lord]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:19 (#4)

שְׂאִי אֵלָיו כַּפַּיִךְ

“Lift up your hands to him”

Here, **lift up your hands** represents the act of praying and pleading with God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Pray earnestly to him]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:19 (#5)

בְּרֹאשׁ כָּל־חוּצוֹת

“at the head of every street”

By the expression **at the head of every street**, the writer means that children are fainting from hunger everywhere. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [everywhere]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 2:20 (#1)

רְאֵה יְהוָה וְהַבִּיטָה

“See, O Yahweh, and look”

The imperatives **See** and **look** communicate a plea or request to God, not a command. If this does not communicate a polite request for your readers, you could use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please see this, Yahweh, and pay attention]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 2:20 (#2)

לְמִי עוֹלַלְתָּ כֹּה אִם־תֹּאכַלְנָה נָשִׁים פִּרְיָם֙ עֹלְלֵ֣י טִפֻּחִ֔ים
אִם־יֵהָרֵ֥ג בְּמִקְדַּשׁ אֲדֹנָי כֹּהֵן וְנָבִיא

“To whom have you dealt thus? Should women eat their fruit, children of {their} nursing? Should priest and prophet be slain in the sanctuary of the Lord”

The writer uses rhetorical questions to express grief that God would allow his own people to suffer so terribly, to express outrage that women have been driven to eat their own children, and to express shock that religious leaders have been killed in the very place that was meant to be holy and safe. The expected answer to all these questions is “No!” If you would not use rhetorical questions for these purposes in your language, you could translate these as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [You have never dealt with anyone else this way! It is terrible that women are eating their own children! It is horrible that priests and prophets have been killed in the sanctuary of the Lord!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 2:20 (#3)

פִּרְיָם֙

“their fruit”

The expression **their fruit** was a common expression meaning their children or offspring. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their children]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:20 (#4)

כֹּהֵן וְנָבִיא

“priest and prophet”

The writer is referring to all of Israel’s religious leaders by naming two representative roles, **priest** and **prophet**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all their religious leaders]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:21 (#1)

נַ֣עַר וְזָקֵ֔ן

“Young and old”

The writer is referring to people of every age by naming two extremes, **Young** and **old**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [People of all ages]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:21 (#2)

בְּתוּלֹתַ֥י וּבַחוּרָ֖י

“My young women and my young men”

Jeremiah is referring to all the young people of the community by naming both groups, **my young women** and **my young men**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [All the young among my people]

See: Merism

Lamentations 2:21 (#3)

נָפְל֥וּ בֶחָ֖רֶב

“have fallen by the sword”

The expression **have fallen by the sword** was a common expression meaning to be killed in battle. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have been killed in battle]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 2:21 (#4)

בְּי֣וֹם אַפֶּ֔ךָ

“on the day of your anger”

The writer is using the expression **on the day of your anger** to refer to the specific time when God executed judgment. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when you were angry and judged us]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:21 (#5)

חָמַ֖לְתָּ

“shown compassion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. See how you translated this phrase in [2:17]. Alternate translation: [spared anyone]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:22 (#1)

תִּקְרָ֤א כְיוֹם֙ מוֹעֵ֔ד מְגוּרַ֖י מִסָּבִ֑יב

“You have summoned, as on a day of an appointed festival, my terrors from all around”

The point of this comparison is that just as guests are invited to **an appointed festival**, so has God **summoned** numerous **terrors from all around**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [You have invited terrors to attack me from all around, as if calling guests to a festival]

See: Simile

Lamentations 2:22 (#2)

מְגוּרַ֖י מִסָּבִ֑יב

“my terrors from all around”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **terrors**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [enemies who terrify me from every side]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 2:22 (#3)

בְּי֣וֹם אַף־יְהוָ֔ה

“on the day of the anger of Yahweh”

The writer is using the expression **the day of the anger of Yahweh** to refer to the time of divine judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when Yahweh was angry and executed his judgment]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 2:22 (#4)

פָּלִ֥יט וְשָׂרִ֖יד

“an escapee or a survivor”

The terms **an escapee** and **a survivor** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together to emphasize that absolutely no one got away. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [any one at all who escaped]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:22 (#5)

אֲשֶׁר־טִפַּחְתִּי֙ וְרִבִּיתִ֔י

“Those whom I carried and multiplied”

The terms **carried** and **multiplied** are paired to express the full cycle of motherhood, both bearing and

nurturing children. The writer speaks as a mother figure who carried and raised these people. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express this with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [All those whom I lovingly reared]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 2:22 (#6)

אֹיְבִי כִלָּם

“my enemy has consumed them”

The writer is speaking of the enemy’s total destruction of the people as if the enemy had **consumed** them like food. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my enemy has completely destroyed them]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This individual lament uses a triple acrostic: each Hebrew letter governs three verses (66 total), far more elaborate than the book’s other poems. It moves from sustained suffering to hope in Yahweh’s faithfulness, then to communal lament.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Covenant faithfulness

Verses 22–23 form the theological center of the book, declaring that Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness never ends and is renewed each morning. Translators should use a consistent term for this concept throughout Lamentations.

Lamentations 3:1 (#1)

עֳנִי

“affliction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **affliction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how he has afflicted me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:1 (#2)

רָאָה עֳנִי

“seeing affliction”

The writer is speaking of the experience of **affliction** as if it were something he could see. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [experiencing affliction] or [suffering affliction]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:1 (#3)

בְּשֵׁבֶט עֶבְרָתוֹ

“his wrath”

Here the writer is speaking of God’s punishment as if it were a **rod** used to strike someone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by his angry punishment]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:1 (#4)

עֶבְרָתוֹ

“his wrath”

The pronoun **his** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God’s wrath]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 3:1 (#5)

עֶבְרָתוֹ

“his wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his wrathful punishment]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:2 (#1)

אוֹתִתִי נָהַג

“He drove me”

The pronoun **He** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God drove me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 3:2 (#2)

הֹחַשֵׁךְ וְלֹא־אוֹר

“and not light”

Here the writer is speaking of suffering as if it were **darkness** and of well-being as if it were **light**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in suffering and not relief]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:3 (#1)

יַהֲפֹךְ יָדוֹ

“he turns his hand”

Here, **his hand** represents God’s power and action. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he directs his power against me]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:3 (#2)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“the day”

The writer is saying **all the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Hyperbole

Lamentations 3:4 (#1)

בְּשָׂרִי֙ וְעוֹרִ֔י

“and my skin”

The terms **my flesh** and **my skin** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my whole body]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:5 (#1)

בָּנָה עָלַ֙י וַיַּקַּ֣ף

“He built against me and surrounded {me”

Here the writer is speaking of God’s opposition as if God built siege works **against** him and **surrounded** him like an army besieging a city. Your language may have comparable expressions that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He set himself against me and hemmed me in]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:5 (#2)

רֹ֖אשׁ וּתְלָאָֽה

“with} poison and hardship”

The terms **poison** and **hardship** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with bitter suffering]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:6 (#1)

בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּ֔ים הוֹשִׁיבַ֖נִי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּ֔ים הוֹשִׁיבַ֖נִי”

Here the writer is speaking as if God had placed him in **dark places**, the realm where the forgotten dead dwell without hope. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has made me dwell in a place of utter despair]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:6 (#2)

כְּמֵתֵ֥י עוֹלָֽם

“of long ago”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the dead of long ago** are forgotten and have no hope, so the writer feels completely hopeless, as though no one remembers him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as if I were among those who have been dead and forgotten for a long time]

See: Simile

Lamentations 3:7 (#1)

גָּדַ֤ר בַּעֲדִי֙ וְלֹ֣א אֵצֵ֔א

“and I cannot go out”

By **He walled me in, and I cannot go out**, the writer means that God caused him to be imprisoned so that he could not leave (see Jeremiah 37:15–16). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would

be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He caused me to be confined so that I cannot escape]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:7 (#2)

הִכְבִּ֣יד נְחָשְׁתִּ֔י

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הִכְבִּ֣יד נְחָשְׁתִּ֔י"

By **he made my chains heavy**, the writer means that God caused him to be bound in heavy chains (see Jeremiah 40:1). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he caused me to be bound with heavy chains]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:8 (#1)

אֶזְעַ֥ק וַאֲשַׁוֵּ֖עַ

"I cry out"

The terms **I cry out** and **call for help** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I desperately plead for help]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:8 (#2)

שָׂתַ֥ם תְּפִלָּתִֽי

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׂתַ֥ם תְּפִלָּתִֽי"

Here the writer is speaking of his **prayer** as if it were a physical object that God **shuts out** or blocks. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he refuses to hear my plea]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:9 (#1)

גָּדַ֤ר דְּרָכַי֙ בְּגָזִ֔ית

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: גָּדַ֤ר דְּרָכַי֙ בְּגָזִ֔ית"

Here the writer is speaking of his life direction as if it were a way or path, and of God blocking his progress as if God had **walled up** those **ways** with **hewn stone**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has blocked every direction I try to go with solid obstacles]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:9 (#2)

נְתִיבֹתַ֖י עִוָּֽה

"my paths"

Here the writer is speaking of his life direction as if it were **paths**, and of God confusing his plans as if God had made those paths **crooked**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has confused every direction I try to go]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:9 (#3)

גָּדַ֤ר דְּרָכַי֙ בְּגָזִ֔ית נְתִיבֹתַ֖י עִוָּֽה

"my paths"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [He has thoroughly blocked every path I try to take]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 3:10 (#1)

דֹּ֥ב אֹרֵ֛ב הוּא־לִ֖י

"He {is & lying in ambush to me"

Here the writer is speaking of God as if he were **a bear lying in ambush**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He waits to attack me like a bear]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:10 (#2)

דֹּ֥ב אֹרֵ֛ב הוּא־לִ֖י אריה בְּמִסְתָּרִֽים

"He {is & lying in ambush to me, a lion"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [He lies in wait to attack me like a dangerous wild animal]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 3:10 (#3)

אריה בְּמִסְתָּרִים

“a lion”

Here the writer is speaking of God as if he were **a lion in hiding places**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [like a lion hiding and waiting to pounce]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:10 (#4)

אריה בְּמִסְתָּרִים

“a lion”

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he is like a lion waiting to attack me in hiding places]

See: Ellipsis

Lamentations 3:11 (#1)

דְּרָכַי סוֹרֵר

“He turned aside my ways”

Here the writer is speaking of his life as if it were paths or **ways** that God **turned aside**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He diverted my course]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:12 (#1)

דָּרַךְ קַשְׁתּוֹ וַיַּצִּיבֵנִי

“He bent his bow and set me up”

Here the writer is speaking of God as if he were an archer who **bent his bow** and aimed at him as a target. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He prepared to attack me and made me]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:12 (#2)

כַּמַּטָּרָא לַחֵץ

“like a target for the arrow”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **target** is set up to be struck by arrows, so God has set the writer up to receive his arrows of affliction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as something to be struck by the arrow]

See: Simile

Lamentations 3:13 (#1)

הֵבִיא בְּכִלְיוֹתָי

“He caused to enter”

Here the writer is speaking of God’s affliction as if God were an archer whose arrows pierced his **kidneys**, representing deep inner pain. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He shot deep into my body]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:13 (#2)

בְּנֵי אַשְׁפָּתוֹ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּנֵי אַשְׁפָּתוֹ”

The writer is speaking of the arrows as if they were **sons of his quiver**. If your language has a comparable expression, you can use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the arrows from his quiver]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:14 (#1)

הָיִיתִי שְׂחֹקַק לְכָל־עַמִּי נְגִינָתָם כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“I became a laughingstock to all my people, their mocking song all the day”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I have become a constant source of ridicule to my people]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 3:14 (#2)

הָיִיתִי שְׂחֹקַק לְכָל־עַמִּי

“I became a laughingstock to all my people”

Here the writer is speaking of becoming an object of ridicule as if he literally **became a laughingstock**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I became an object of mockery to all my people]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:14 (#3)

לְכָל־עַמְּמִי

“to all my people”

The writer is saying **all my people** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [to my people]

See: Hyperbole

Lamentations 3:15 (#1)

הִשְׂבִּיעַנִי בַמְּרוֹרִים הִרְוַנִי לַעֲנָה

“he saturated me {with} wormwood”

The writer is speaking of God imposing bitter suffering on him as if God had literally **filled** him **with bitter herbs** and **saturated** him **with wormwood**. Your language may have comparable expressions that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has filled my life with bitter and overwhelming experiences]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:15 (#2)

הִשְׂבִּיעַנִי בַמְּרוֹרִים הִרְוַנִי לַעֲנָה

“he saturated me {with} wormwood”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [He has completely filled me with bitter suffering]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 3:15 (#3)

לַעֲנָה

“with} wormwood”

Here, **wormwood** refers to a plant that tastes very bitter. If your readers would not be familiar with this plant, you could use the name of a bitter-tasting plant in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [with a bitter-tasting plant]

See: Translate Unknowns

Lamentations 3:16 (#1)

וַיַּגְרֵס בֶּחָצָץ שִׁנָּנִי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וַיַּגְרֵס בֶּחָצָץ שִׁנָּנִי”

Here the writer is speaking of his degrading humiliation as if God had literally made his **teeth grind on gravel**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has humiliated me in a degrading way]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:16 (#2)

הִכְפִּישַׁנִי בָּאֵפֶר

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הִכְפִּישַׁנִי בָּאֵפֶר”

The writer is speaking of being brought low in mourning and shame as if God had literally **pressed** him **down in the ashes**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has brought me low in shame]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:17 (#1)

וַתִּזְנַח מִשָּׁלוֹם נַפְשִׁי

“And my soul was deprived of peace”

The phrase **was deprived** is a passive verbal form. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God deprived my soul of peace] or [God deprived me of peace]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 3:17 (#2)

מִשָּׁלוֹם

“of peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of anything peaceful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:17 (#3)

טוֹבָה

“good”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **good**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is good]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:18 (#1)

וָאֹמַר֙ אָבַ֣ד נִצְחִ֔י וְתוֹחַלְתִּ֖י מֵיְהוָֽה

“And I said, “My endurance has perished, and my hope from Yahweh”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could translate this so that there is not a direct quotation but an indirect one. Alternate translation: [And I said that my endurance has perished, as has my hope from Yahweh]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 3:18 (#2)

אָבַ֣ד נִצְחִ֔י וְתוֹחַלְתִּ֖י מֵיְהוָֽה

“My endurance has perished, and my hope from Yahweh”

Here the writer is speaking of his **endurance** and **hope** as if they were living things that could **perish**. Your language may have comparable expressions that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My ability to endure is gone and my expectation that Yahweh would help me]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:18 (#3)

נִצְחִ֔י וְתוֹחַלְתִּ֖י

“My endurance & and my hope”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **endurance** and **hope**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [My ability to endure ... and my reason to hope]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:19 (#1)

זְכָר־עָנְיִ֥י וּמְרוּדַ֖י

“Remember my affliction and my wandering”

The writer is using the imperative form **Remember** to make a request to God, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remember my affliction and my wandering]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 3:19 (#2)

זְכָר־עָנְיִ֥י וּמְרוּדַ֖י

“Remember my affliction and my wandering”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **affliction** and **wandering**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Remember how I have been afflicted and how I have wandered]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:19 (#3)

עָנְיִ֥י וּמְרוּדַ֖י

“my affliction and my wandering”

The terms **my affliction** and **my wandering** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my great distress]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:19 (#4)

לַ֥עֲנָנָה וָרֹֽאשׁ

“the wormwood and the poison”

The terms **the wormwood** and **the poison** mean similar things. The writer again is using the two terms together for emphasis and here also you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the overwhelming bitterness]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:19 (#5)

לַ֥עֲנָנָה וָרֹֽאשׁ

“the wormwood and the poison”

Here the writer speaks of his bitter suffering as if it were **wormwood** and **poison** that he was forced to taste. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could

state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the overwhelming bitterness of my experience]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:20 (#1)

זָכֹר תִּזְכֹּר

“Remembering, it remembers”

The writer is repeating forms of the verb **remembering, it remembers** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [It certainly remembers]

See: Reduplication

Lamentations 3:20 (#2)

תִּזְכֹּר

“it remembers”

The subject of the verb translated **it remembers** is ambiguous. This likely refers to the writer’s soul continuing to remember the suffering described in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [my soul remembers] or [I remember]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 3:20 (#3)

ותשיח עָלַ֖י נַפְשִֽׁי

“and my soul bows down upon me”

The writer speaks of his **soul** as if it were a person who **bows down**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I am bowed down]

See: Personification

Lamentations 3:21 (#1)

זֹ֣את אָשִׁ֔יב אֶל־לִבִּ֖י

“This & to”

Here, **This** refers forward to what the writer is about to say, not back to what he has just described. Alternate translation: [This is what I recall]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:21 (#2)

אָשִׁ֔יב אֶל־לִבִּ֖י

“to”

Here the **heart** represents where the writer’s thoughts and emotions exist. He is speaking of recalling something as if he were physically bringing it **back to** his **heart**. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I recall in my mind]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:21 (#3)

עַל־כֵּ֥ן אוֹחִֽיל

“therefore I will hope”

The word translated as **therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what the writer has just brought back to mind. Use a word or phrase that makes this relationship clear. Alternate translation: [and so I will hope]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Lamentations 3:22 (#1)

כִּ֚י לֹא־תָ֣מְנ֔וּ

“for we have not perished”

Many ancient manuscripts read **for we have not been consumed**, with the writer and the people as the subject. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “his steadfast love has not ceased,” with the steadfast love of Yahweh as the subject. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Lamentations 3:22 (#2)

חֲסְדֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה & רַחֲמָ֖יו

“The covenant faithfulness of Yahweh & his compassions”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **compassions**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh is faithful to his covenant ... his compassionate actions continue and]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:23 (#1)

חֲדָשִׁ֥ים לַבְּקָרִ֖ים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: חֲדָשִׁים לַבְּקָרִים”

The pronoun **They** refers to “the compassionate actions” of Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [His compassion renews every morning]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 3:23 (#2)

רַבָּה אֱמוּנָתֶךָ

“your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you are always faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:24 (#1)

חֶלְקִי יְהוָה אָמְרָה נַפְשִׁי

“Yahweh {is} my portion,” my soul said”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could translate this so that there is not a direct quotation but an indirect one. Alternate translation: [I realized that Yahweh is all I need]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 3:24 (#2)

חֶלְקִי יְהוָה

“Yahweh {is} my portion”

Here the writer is speaking of Yahweh as if he were an inherited **portion** of land. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is like my inheritance]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:24 (#3)

אָמְרָה נַפְשִׁי

“my soul said”

Here, **my soul** represents the writer himself from the perspective of his inner being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I said to myself]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:24 (#4)

עַל־כֵּן אוֹחִיל לוֹ

“therefore I will hope in him”

The word **therefore** here indicates that what follows is a result of Yahweh being his portion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a word or phrase that makes this relationship clear. Alternate translation: [and so I will hope in him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Lamentations 3:25 (#1)

לְנֶפֶשׁ תִּדְרְשֶׁנּוּ

“to the soul {that”

Here, **the soul** represents the person who seeks God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the person who seeks him]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:26 (#1)

לִתְשׁוּעַת

“for the salvation of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the saving act of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:27 (#1)

לַגָּבֶר

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַגָּבֶר”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [for anyone]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Lamentations 3:27 (#2)

כִּי־יִשָּׂא עֹל בִּנְעוּרָיו

“a yoke”

Here the writer is speaking of discipline and suffering as if they were a **yoke** placed on a person’s shoulders. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the

meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [if he endures discipline in his youth]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:27 (#3)

כִּי־יִשָּׂא עֹל֖ בִּנְעוּרָֽיו

“a yoke”

Here, **that he bears a yoke in his youth** introduces a possible condition. It is good for a man only if this happens. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [when he bears a yoke in his youth]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Lamentations 3:28 (#1)

יֵשֵׁ֤ב בָּדָד֙ וְיִדֹּ֔ם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: יֵשֵׁ֤ב בָּדָד֙ וְיִדֹּ֔ם”

The writer is using the third-person imperative form **Let him sit** to give instruction about what a person should do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team here and elsewhere in this lament. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this with a different form that communicates instruction or exhortation. Alternate translation: [He should sit alone and be silent] or [I desire that he sit alone and be silent]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Lamentations 3:28 (#2)

נָטַ֥ל עָלָֽיו

“he has laid {it} upon him”

The pronoun **he** in **he has laid** refers to God, while the pronoun **him** refers to the suffering person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God has laid it upon him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 3:29 (#1)

יִתֵּ֤ן בֶּעָפָר֙ פִּ֔יהוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: יִתֵּ֤ן בֶּעָפָר֙ פִּ֔יהוּ”

In the writer’s culture, putting one’s **mouth in the dust** was a symbolic action that signified extreme humility and submission before God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Let him humble himself completely before God]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 3:29 (#2)

תִּקְוָֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: תִּקְוָֽה”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [something to hope for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:30 (#1)

יִתֵּ֤ן לְמַכֵּ֙הוּ֙ לֶחִ֔י

“Let him give {his} cheek to the one striking him”

In the writer’s culture, giving one’s **cheek to the one striking him** was a symbolic action that signified patient acceptance of suffering and willingness to endure insult without retaliation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Let him patiently accept the blows of the one who strikes him]

See: Symbolic Action

Lamentations 3:30 (#2)

בְּחֶרְפָּֽה

“with reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with insults]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:31 (#1)

כִּֽי־ לֹ֥א יִזְנַ֖ח לְעוֹלָ֥ם אֲדֹנָֽי

“the Lord will not reject forever”

The word **For** here indicates that what follows is the reason for the exhortation in the preceding verses. Use a word or phrase in your language that makes it clear that what follows is the reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [The reason is that the Lord will not reject forever]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Lamentations 3:32 (#1)

כִּֽי־אִם־הוֹגָ֔ה וְרִחַ֖ם

“though he causes grief, he will have compassion”

The words **For though** introduce a contrast between what God does temporarily and what he will do ultimately. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Even though he causes grief, he will still have compassion]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Lamentations 3:32 (#2)

אִם־הוֹגָ֔ה וְרִחַ֖ם כְּרֹ֣ב חסדו

“though he causes grief, he will have compassion & his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **grief**, **compassion**, and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [even though he grieves people, he will show them that he is compassionate because he is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:33 (#1)

לֹ֤א עִנָּה֙ מִלִּבּ֔וֹ

“he does not afflict”

Here the **heart** represents God’s true desire and will. The writer is saying that God does not afflict people because he desires to do so. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he does not willingly afflict]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:33 (#2)

בְּנֵי־אִֽישׁ

“the sons of man”

Although the writer uses the masculine term **the sons of man**, he means this to apply to people in general, both men and women. If it would be helpful in your language, you could include language that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Lamentations 3:34 (#1)

לְדַכֵּ֣א תַּחַת רַגְלָ֔יו כֹּ֖ל אֲסִירֵ֥י אָֽרֶץ

“his feet & the prisoners of {the} earth”

The infinitive phrases in this verse and the following verses list actions that precede the main statement in verse 36. If it would be helpful in your language, you could restructure this so that the relationship between these actions and the main statement is clear. Alternate translation: [When anyone crushes under his feet all the prisoners of the earth]

See: Information Structure

Lamentations 3:34 (#2)

תַּחַת רַגְלָ֔יו

“his feet”

Here, **under his feet** represents dominion and oppressive power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [under his authority]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:35 (#1)

מִשְׁפַּ֥ט

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִשְׁפַּט”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the right to be judged justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:35 (#2)

נֶ֖גֶד פְּנֵ֥י עֶלְיֽוֹן

“before & the Most High”

Here, **before the face of the Most High** represents being in the presence of the Most High. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of the Most High]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:36 (#1)

לְעַוֵּ֥ת אָדָ֖ם בְּרִיבֽוֹ

“to pervert a man in his dispute”

The writer is speaking of acting unjustly toward someone as if it were physically twisting or distorting him, using the same image as "turn aside" in the previous verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to deal unjustly with a man in his legal case]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:36 (#2)

אֲדֹנָי לֹא רָאָה

"the Lord does not see {it"

This could mean: (1) that the Lord does not regard with approval the wrong actions described in verses 34–36. Alternate translation: [the Lord does not approve] or (2) that the author is using the question form for emphasis. Alternate translation: [does the Lord not see it?] or [the Lord certainly sees it!]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:37 (#1)

מִמַּי זֶּה אָמַר֙ וַתֶּ֔הִי אֲדֹנָי֙ לֹ֣א צִוָּֽה

"Who {is} this {who} spoke & Did} the Lord not"

The writer is using these questions to emphasize that no one can speak something into existence apart from God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express these questions as statements here and in verses 38–39. Alternate translation: [No one can speak and make it happen unless God has ordained it.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 3:38 (#1)

מִפִּ֥י עֶלְיוֹן֙

"the Most High"

Here, **the mouth of the Most High** represents the decrees and commands of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From the decree of the Most High]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:38 (#2)

הָרָעָ֖ות וְהַטּֽוֹב

"the evil things and the good"

Jeremiah is referring to everything that happens by naming two extremes, **the evil things** and **the good**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all things, whether bad or good]

See: Merism

Lamentations 3:39 (#1)

אָדָ֕ם חָ֖י גֶּ֑בֶר

"a living man & a man"

Although the writer uses the masculine terms **a living man** and **a man**, he means these to apply to people in general, both men and women. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [a living person ... a person]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Lamentations 3:39 (#2)

עַל־חטאו

"about his sins"

By **about his sins**, the writer means "about the punishment he receives for his sins." You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [about his punishment for sin]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:40 (#1)

נַחְפְּשָׂ֥ה דְרָכֵ֛ינוּ וְנַחְקֹ֖רָה

"our ways and examine {them"

Here the writer is speaking of examining conduct and behavior as if it were **ways** or paths that a person could **search**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let us carefully examine our conduct]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:40 (#2)

נַחְפְּשָׂ֥ה דְרָכֵ֛ינוּ

"our ways"

Here the pronouns **us** and **our** do not include God, whom the community is addressing. The writer is speaking on behalf of himself and the people but not God, so use the exclusive form of the word if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive 'We'

Lamentations 3:40 (#3)

נַחְפְּשָׂה דְרָכֵינוּ וְנַחְקֹרָה

“our ways and examine {them”

The terms **search** and **examine** mean similar things. Jeremiah is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let us carefully examine our conduct]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:41 (#1)

נִשָּׂא לְבָבֵנוּ

“our hearts”

Here the **heart** represents the inner being and affections. The writer is speaking of directing his heart toward God as if it were something he could **lift up**. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let us direct our innermost being in prayer]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:41 (#2)

לְבָבֵנוּ אֶל־כַּפָּיִם

“our hearts with”

Here the pronouns **our** do not include God, whom the community is addressing. The writer is speaking on behalf of himself and the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Lamentations 3:41 (#3)

אֶל־כַּפָּיִם

“with”

Here, **hands** represents the gesture of prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with our hands raised in prayer]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:42 (#1)

נַנַחְנוּ פָּשַׁעְנוּ

“We, we”

The writer is stating the pronoun **We** separately for emphasis, to highlight the community’s guilt. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [It is we who have transgressed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 3:42 (#2)

פָּשַׁעְנוּ וּמָרִינוּ

“and rebelled”

The terms **transgressed** and **rebelled** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [have sinned greatly against you]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:43 (#1)

סַכֹּתָה בָאַף

“You covered {yourself} in nose”

Here the writer is speaking of God’s **nose** as if it were a garment that God **covered** himself with. The nose refers to anger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You were completely consumed by anger]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:43 (#2)

לֹא חָמָלְתָּ

“you did not show pity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pity**, you could express the same idea in other ways. Alternate translation: [you did not show that you pitied us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:44 (#1)

סַכֹּתָה בֶעָנָן לָךְ

“You covered yourself in a cloud”

Here the writer is speaking of a barrier to communication with God as if God had **covered** himself **in a cloud**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You made yourself unreachable]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:44 (#2)

מֵעֲבֹר תְּפִלָּה

“from a prayer passing through”

The phrase **from a prayer passing through** indicates the result of God covering himself in a cloud. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a word or phrase that makes it clear that this is a result of God covering himself in a cloud. Alternate translation: [with the result that no prayer reached you]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Lamentations 3:44 (#3)

מֵעֲבֹר תְּפִלָּה

“from a prayer passing through”

Here the writer is speaking of **prayer** as if it were a physical object that could be blocked from traveling through a barrier. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so that you would not hear any prayer]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:45 (#1)

סְחִי וּמָאוֹס תְּשִׂימֵנוּ

“Offscouring and refuse”

In this verse the object **Offscouring and refuse** comes before the subject and verb **you make** for emphasis. If it would be more natural in your language, you could restructure this to put the subject and verb first. Alternate translation: [You make us offscouring and refuse]

See: Information Structure

Lamentations 3:45 (#2)

סְחִי וּמָאוֹס תְּשִׂימֵנוּ

“Offscouring and refuse”

Here the writer is speaking of the people as if they were **offscouring and refuse**, that is, filth and garbage that others discard. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have made us despised and rejected]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:45 (#3)

סְחִי וּמָאוֹס

“Offscouring and refuse”

The terms **Offscouring** and **refuse** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Worthless waste]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:46 (#1)

פָּצוּ עָלֵינוּ פִּיהֶם

“against us”

The expression **opened their mouth against us** was a common expression meaning “spoke against us with hostility.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [spoke against us with hostility]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 3:47 (#1)

פַּחַד וָפַחַת הָיָה לָנוּ הַשֵּׁשֶׁת וְהַשָּׁבֶר

“and the pit have come to us”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [We have experienced overwhelming terror and utter ruin]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 3:47 (#2)

פַּחַד וָפַחַת הָיָה לָנוּ הַשֵּׁשֶׁת וְהַשָּׁבֶר

“and the pit have come to us”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **Terror**, **desolation**, and **destruction**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Terrifying things have come to us, what makes us desolate and what destroys us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:47 (#3)

פַּחַד וָפַחַת & הַשֵּׁשֶׁת וְהַשָּׁבֶר

“and the pit”

The terms **Terror** and **the pit** mean similar things. Also, the terms **the desolation** and **the destruction** mean similar things. The writer is using two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Overwhelming danger ... utter ruin]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:47 (#4)

הַשֵּׁשֵׁאת וְהַשָּׁבֶר

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הַשֵּׁשֵׁאת וְהַשָּׁבֶר"

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [desolation and destruction have come to us] or [utter ruin has come to us]

See: Ellipsis

Lamentations 3:48 (#1)

פַּלְגֵי־מַ֙יִם֙ תֵּרַ֣ד עֵינִ֔י

"water & my eye"

The writer says **Streams of water go down from my eye** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [Many tears flow from my eye]

See: Hyperbole

Lamentations 3:48 (#2)

פַּלְגֵי־מַ֙יִם֙ תֵּרַ֣ד עֵינִ֔י

"water & my eye"

Here, **my eye** represents the writer himself as the one who is weeping. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I weep profusely]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:48 (#3)

עַל־שֶׁ֖בֶר בַּת־עַמִּֽי

"over"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because my people have been destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:48 (#4)

בַּת־עַמִּֽי

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בַּת־עַמִּֽי"

Here the writer is speaking of his people as if they were a **daughter**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my beloved people]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:49 (#1)

עֵינִ֣י נִגְרָ֔ה וְלֹ֥א תִדְמֶ֖ה

"My eye & and does not cease"

The writer speaks of his **eye** as if it were a person who could **pour out** tears on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I pour out tears and do not cease]

See: Personification

Lamentations 3:49 (#2)

וְלֹ֥א תִדְמֶ֖ה מֵאֵ֥ין הֲפֻגֽוֹת

"and does not cease, without stopping"

The writer says **does not cease, without stopping** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [does not cease for any relief]

See: Hyperbole

Lamentations 3:50 (#1)

עַד־יַשְׁקִ֥יף

"until he looks down"

The word **until** marks the endpoint of the writer's weeping. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a word or phrase that makes this temporal relationship clear. Alternate translation: [until the time when Yahweh looks down]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Lamentations 3:51 (#1)

עֵינִי֙ עוֹלְלָ֣ה לְנַפְשִׁ֔י

"My eye brings grief"

The writer is using the term **eye** to mean what he sees. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What I see brings grief to my soul]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:51 (#2)

לְנַפְשִׁי

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לְנַפְשִׁי"

Here, **my soul** represents the writer himself from the perspective of his inner being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to me]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:51 (#3)

בְּנוֹת עִירִי

"my city"

Here the writer is speaking of the women of his city as **the daughters of my city**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the women of my city]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:52 (#1)

צוֹד צָדוּנִי

"Hunting, they hunted me"

The writer is repeating the verb **Hunting** before the main verb for emphasis, to show the relentless and determined nature of the pursuit. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do so here. If not, your language may have a comparable way to express emphasis. Alternate translation: [They hunted me relentlessly]

See: Reduplication

Lamentations 3:52 (#2)

צוֹד צָדוּנִי כַּצִּפּוֹר

"Hunting, they hunted me"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **bird** is helpless and easily caught by hunters, so the writer's enemies pursued him relentlessly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I was helpless before their pursuit]

See: Simile

Lamentations 3:53 (#1)

צָמְתוּ בַבּוֹר חַיָּי

"They silenced & in the pit"

By **They silenced my life in the pit**, the writer means that his enemies threw him into a cistern intending to kill him (see Jeremiah 38:6). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [They threw me into a cistern to kill me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:54 (#1)

צָפוּ־מַיִם עַל־רֹאשִׁי

"Waters flowed over my head"

By **Waters flowed over my head**, the writer means that water in the cistern rose up around him and he was in danger of drowning (see Jeremiah 38:6). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The water in the cistern rose over my head]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:54 (#2)

נִגְזָרְתִּי

"I am cut off"

The expression **I am cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this with an active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [They have cut me off]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 3:54 (#3)

נִגְזָרְתִּי

"I am cut off"

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could translate this so that there is not a direct quotation but an indirect one. Alternate translation: [that I was cut off]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 3:54 (#4)

נִגְזָרְתִּי

"I am cut off"

The expression **I am cut off** was a common expression meaning I am about to die or I am separated from the living. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am about to die]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 3:55 (#1)

קָרָ֣אתִי שִׁמְךָ֔

“I called on your name”

Here, **your name** represents God himself and his character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I called on you]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:55 (#2)

מִבְּב֖וֹר תַּחְתִּיּוֹת

“from the pit of the depths”

By **the pit of the depths**, Jeremiah means the deepest part of the cistern where his enemies had thrown him (see Jeremiah 38:6). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from the deepest part of the cistern]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 3:56 (#1)

קוֹלִ֣י שָׁמָ֔עְתָּ

“my voice”

Here, **my voice** represents the words the writer spoke in prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You heard my prayer]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:56 (#2)

אַל־תַּעְלֵ֥ם אָזְנְךָ֖

“do not & your ear”

Here, **your ear** represents God’s hearing and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not refuse to listen]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:56 (#3)

אַל־תַּעְלֵ֥ם אָזְנְךָ֖ לְרַוְחָתִ֑י

“do not & your ear to my relief”

The writer is using the imperative form **do not hide** to make a request to God rather than to give a command. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this with a form that communicates a request. Alternate translation: [please do not refuse to hear and come to my aid, and listen]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 3:56 (#4)

לְרַוְחָתִ֑י לְשַׁוְעָתִ֖י

“to my relief”

The terms **my relief** and **my cry for help** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to my desperate plea]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 3:56 (#5)

לְרַוְחָתִ֑י לְשַׁוְעָתִ֖י

“to my relief”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **relief**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I ask you to relieve my pain and cry out for you to help me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:57 (#1)

אַל־תִּירָ֖א

“Do not fear”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could translate this so that there is not a direct quotation but an indirect one. Alternate translation: [not to be afraid]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 3:58 (#1)

רַ֣בְתָּ אֲדֹנָ֔י רִיבֵ֖י נַפְשִׁ֑י

“Lord & the cases of”

Here the writer is speaking of God defending him as if God were a legal advocate who **pleaded** his **cases** in a courtroom. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Lord, you were my legal advocate]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 3:58 (#2)

רִיבֵ֥י נַפְשִׁ֖י

“the cases of”

Here, **my soul** represents the writer himself. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my case]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:59 (#1)

עַוָּ֣תָתִ֔י

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַוָּ֣תָתִ֔י”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **my wrong**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how they have wronged me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:59 (#2)

שָׁפְטָ֥ה מִשְׁפָּטִֽי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׁפְטָ֥ה מִשְׁפָּטִֽי”

The writer is using the imperative form **judge** to make a request to God rather than to give a command. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this with a different form that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [please judge my case]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 3:60 (#1)

כָּל־נִקְמָתָ֖ם כָּל־מַחְשְׁבֹתָ֥ם

“their vengeance”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **vengeance** and **plans**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [all the ways they have tried to harm me and how they scheme against me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:61 (#1)

חֶרְפָּתָ֣ם יְהוָ֔ה כָּל־מַחְשְׁבֹתָ֖ם

“Yahweh”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **reproach** and **plans**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how they reproach me and everything they plan against me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:62 (#1)

שִׂפְתֵ֥י קָמַ֛י

“those rising”

Here, **the lips of those rising against me** represents the hostile speech of the writer’s enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the words of those who oppose]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:63 (#1)

שִׁבְתָּ֣ם וְקִימָתָ֔ם הַבִּיטָ֖ה

“and their rising”

The writer is using the imperative form **Look** to make a polite request to God rather than to give a command. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this with a different form that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [Please observe their sitting and their rising]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 3:63 (#2)

שִׁבְתָּ֣ם וְקִימָתָ֔ם

“and their rising”

The writer is referring to everything his enemies do by naming two major components, **their sitting** and **their rising**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everything they do]

See: Merism

Lamentations 3:64 (#1)

גְּמֻ֥ל

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: גְּמֻ֥ל”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **recompense**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what they deserve]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 3:64 (#2)

כְּמַעֲשֵׂ֥ה יְדֵיהֶֽם

“their hands”

Here, **their hands** represents the actions and deeds of the writer’s enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [according to their evil actions]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 3:65 (#1)

מָגִנַּת־לֵ֔ב

“heart”

The expression **a covering of heart** was a common expression meaning spiritual stubbornness or obstinacy of mind. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [stubborn minds]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 3:66 (#1)

בְּאַ֣רְּפְךָ֔

“in nose”

The writer is using the phrase **in nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean in anger. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your fury] or [because you are angry]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 3:66 (#2)

מִתַּ֥חַת שְׁמֵ֖י יְהוָֽה

“from under the heavens of Yahweh”

Here the writer is speaking of the realm of the living as being **under the heavens of Yahweh**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the face of the earth]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations - Chapter 4 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Lamentations 4 is a 22–verse acrostic poem, with each verse beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. The poem moves from vivid images of degradation — tarnished gold, starving children, cannibalism — to the fall of Jerusalem’s prophets, priests, and king, closing with a warning to Edom and a word of hope that Zion’s punishment is complete.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The anointed of Yahweh

Verse 20 calls the king “the anointed of Yahweh” and “the breath of our nostrils.” This royal language expresses the deep trust the people placed in the king as God’s appointed ruler. Translators should use a term for “anointed” consistent with how it is used elsewhere, since the same concept applies to priests and, ultimately, to the Messiah.

Daughter of Edom and daughter of Zion

The chapter closes by addressing “daughter of Edom” and “daughter of Zion” as if they were women. This is a common Hebrew way of personifying a city or nation.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Iniquity as sin or punishment

In verses 6 and 22, the word “iniquity” can mean either the sin itself or the punishment for sin. Translators should choose one reading and apply it consistently within each verse, since the two clauses in each verse are parallel.

Lamentations 4:1 (#1)

אֵיכָ֤ה

“How”

The word **How** introduces an exclamation of sorrow which expresses strong feelings of shock and grief at the way the people of Zion are now treated. This is poetic language and begins the lament for the destruction of Jerusalem and its people. If there is an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation, you could use it here and in verse 2.

See: Poetry

Lamentations 4:1 (#2)

יוּעַ֙ם זָהָ֔ב יִשְׁנֶ֖א הַכֶּ֥תֶם הַטָּטֽוֹב

“the gold is tarnished; {people} have changed the good fine gold”

Here the writer is speaking as if the people of Jerusalem were **gold** that has lost its luster and **fine gold** that has been altered. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people have lost their value; the most honored people have changed]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:1 (#3)

תִּשְׁתַּפַּכְנָה אַבְנֵי־קֹדֶשׁ

“The stones of holiness are poured out”

Here the writer is speaking as if the people of the city were **The stones of holiness** and liquid that has been **poured out** and scattered. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The holy stones lie scattered] or [The people lie scattered]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:1 (#4)

בְּרֹ֣אשׁ כָּל־חוּצ֔וֹת

“at the head of every street”

The writer is using **at the head of every street** as a common expression of the culture to mean at the beginning or top of every street. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on every street corner] or [at the top of every street]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 4:2 (#1)

בְּנֵי֙ צִיּ֔וֹן הַיְקָרִ֖ים הַמְסֻלָּאִ֑ים בַּפָּ֗ז

“The precious sons of Zion, weighed against fine gold”

Here the writer is speaking as if the people of Jerusalem were precious metal that could be **weighed against fine gold**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The precious sons of Zion, as valuable as fine gold]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:2 (#2)

הַמְסֻלָּאִים בַּפָּז

“weighed against fine gold”

The expression **weighed against fine gold** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whose value equaled fine gold]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 4:2 (#3)

אֵיכָ֗ה נֶחְשְׁב֤וּ לְנִבְלֵי־חֶ֙רֶשׂ֙

“how they are regarded as jars of clay”

The point of this comparison is that just as **jars of clay** are cheap and easily broken, so the sons of Zion are now treated as worthless. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [how people regard them as worthless, like jars of clay]

See: Simile

Lamentations 4:3 (#1)

בַּת־עַמִּ֖י לְאַכְזָ֑ר

“But} the daughter of my people {has} become cruel”

The writer is speaking of **the daughter of my people** as if the people group were one woman. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly here and in verse 10. Alternate translation: [But my people have become cruel]

See: Personification

Lamentations 4:3 (#2)

כִּ֥י עֲנִ֛ים בַּמִּדְבָּ֖ר

“like ostriches in the wilderness”

The point of this comparison is that just as **ostriches in the wilderness** abandon their eggs and neglect their young, so the people have become cruel to their children. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like ostriches in the wilderness that abandon their young]

See: Simile

Lamentations 4:4 (#1)

חִכַּךְ

“the roof of his mouth”

Here, the writer is speaking of the top of the infant’s mouth as if it were a **roof**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the top of his mouth] or [his palate]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:5 (#1)

הָאֱמֻנִים֙ עַל־תּוֹלָ֔עַ

“The ones reared on scarlet”

Here, **scarlet** represents expensive dyed clothing. The expression **The ones reared on scarlet** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Those whose parents raised them in fine clothes]

See: Active or Passive

Lamentations 4:6 (#1)

וַיִּגְדַּל֙ עֲוֹן֙ בַּת־עַמִּ֔י מֵחַטַּאת סְדֹ֑ם

“And the iniquity of the daughter of my people is greater than the sin of Sodom”

Here, **iniquity** could represent: (1) the sin itself, meaning the sinfulness of the people is worse than the sinfulness of Sodom. Alternate translation: [the wickedness of the daughter of my people is greater than the wickedness of Sodom] or (2) the punishment for sin, meaning God has punished the people more severely than he punished Sodom. The UST follows this reading. Alternate translation: [the punishment of the daughter of my people is greater than the punishment of Sodom]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:6 (#2)

וַיִּגְדַּל֙ עֲוֹן֙ בַּת־עַמִּ֔י מֵחַטַּאת סְדֹ֑ם

“And the iniquity of the daughter of my people is greater than the sin of Sodom”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **iniquity** and **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the way the daughter of my people has acted wickedly is worse than the way Sodom sinned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 4:6 (#3)

וְלֹא־חָ֥לוּ בָ֖הּ יָדִ֑ים

“and hands did not tremble for her”

This could mean: (1) no one expressed grief for Sodom, that is, no one wrung their hands in anguish over its destruction. Alternate translation: [and no one grieved for her] or (2) no human hands were involved in its destruction because God destroyed it suddenly. Alternate translation: [and no hands helped her]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 4:7 (#1)

נְזִירֶ֖יהָ

“Her Nazirites”

This could mean: (1) **Nazirites** refers to people who had taken a special vow of dedication to God, as described in Numbers 6:1–21. Their pure appearance would reflect their consecrated life. Alternate translation: [Her consecrated ones] or (2) the word refers more generally to nobles, leaders, or people who were set apart by their high position. The UST follows this reading. Alternate translation: [Her nobles]

See: Translate Unknowns

Lamentations 4:7 (#2)

זַכּ֤וּ & מִשֶּׁ֙שֶׁלֶג֙ צַחֲח֣וּ מֵחָלָ֔ב

“were purer & they were whiter than milk”

The point of this comparison is that just as **snow** and **milk** are bright and clean, so the Nazirites had a pure appearance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [were as clean looking as snow; their appearance was as bright as milk]

See: Simile

Lamentations 4:7 (#3)

אָאְדְּמ֤וּ עֶ֙צֶם֙ מִפְּנִינִ֔ים סַפִּ֖יר גִּזְרָתָֽם

“Their bones were more ruddy”

The point of this comparison is that just as **corals** have a rich red color and **sapphire** is very precious, so the Nazirites’ bodies had a healthy, ruddy complexion and fine form. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Their complexion was as healthy-looking as coral; their form was as beautiful as sapphire]

See: Simile

Lamentations 4:8 (#1)

חָשַׁשָׂ֣ךְ מִשְּׁחוֹר֮

“is darker than soot”

The point of this comparison is that just as **soot** is very dark, so the appearance of the people has become extremely dark because of starvation and suffering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [is extremely dark]

See: Simile

Lamentations 4:8 (#2)

יָבֵ֣שׁ הָיָ֔ה כָּעֵֽץ

“it has become dry as wood”

The point of this comparison is that just as **wood** is dry and lifeless, so the skin of the starving people has become dried out. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [it has become dry and lifeless like a piece of wood]

See: Simile

Lamentations 4:9 (#1)

חַלְלֵי־חֶ֖רֶב

“the slain of the sword”

Here, **the slain of the sword** represents those who died in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [those who died by the sword in battle]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:9 (#2)

שֶׁ֣הֵ֔מָּה יָזֹ֖בוּ מְדֻקָּרִ֑ים מִתְנוּבְּלֹ֥ת שָׂדָֽי

“for they waste away, pierced for lack of the fruits of the field”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [because there was no food from the fields, they wasted away, pierced by hunger]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Lamentations 4:10 (#1)

יְדֵ֣י נָשִׁ֔ים רַחֲמָנִיּ֖וֹת

“The hands of compassionate”

Here, **The hands of compassionate women** represents the women themselves and their actions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Compassionate women themselves]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:10 (#2)

הָי֥וּ לְבָרוֹתָ֖ם לְלָמֽוֹ

“they became food for them”

The pronoun **they** refers to the children, while the pronoun **them** refers to the women.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 4:11 (#1)

חֲרָ֣ון אַפּ֔וֹ

“the burning of his nose”

The writer is using **the burning of his nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean that Yahweh is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his fierce anger] or [his burning anger]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 4:12 (#1)

בְּשַׁעֲרֵ֖י יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּשַׁעֲרֵ֖י יְרוּשָׁלָֽם”

Here, **the gates of Jerusalem** represents the city itself and its defenses. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the city of Jerusalem]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:13 (#1)

מֵֽחַטֹּ֣אות נְבִיאֶ֔יהָ עֲוֹנֹ֖ות כֹּהֲנֶ֑יהָ

“Because of the sins of her prophets, the iniquities of her priests”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. The pronoun **her**

in the phrases **her prophets** and **her priests** refers to Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [Because of the great wickedness of her religious leaders]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 4:13 (#2)

הַשֹּׁפְכִים & דַּם צַדִּיקִים

“the ones pouring out the blood of the righteous”

Here, **pouring out the blood of the righteous** represents killing innocent people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [killing righteous people]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:14 (#1)

נָעֲעוּ עִוְרִים בָּחוּצוֹת

“They wandered blind”

Here the writer is speaking as if the prophets and priests were physically **blind**. He means that they had no moral or spiritual discernment, and now after Jerusalem’s destruction they wander helplessly through the streets. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They wandered through the streets without direction, unable to see what they had done]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:14 (#2)

נְגֹאֲלוּ בַדָּם

“they were defiled”

Here, **blood** represents the guilt of having murdered innocent people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they were guilty of shedding innocent blood] or [the blood of their victims defiled them]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:15 (#1)

סָרוּ טָמֵא קָרְאוּ לָמוֹ סָרוּ סָרוּ אַל־תִּגָּעוּ

“Turn aside! Unclean!” they called to them. “Turn aside! Turn aside! Do not touch”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express these as indirect quotations. The verse contains direct quotations of what people shouted at the defiled priests and prophets. The first pronoun **they** refers to the people of the city, while the pronoun **them** refers to the priests and prophets. Alternate translation: [People shouted at them to turn aside because they were unclean, and told them to go away and not to touch anyone]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 4:15 (#2)

אָמְרוּ בַגּוֹיִם לֹא יוֹסִיפוּ לָגוּר

“They said among the nations, “They shall not continue to sojourn”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. The first **They** refers to the people of the nations while the second **They** refers to the priests and prophets. Alternate translation: [They said among the nations that those priests and prophets could not continue to live there]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 4:16 (#1)

פְּנֵי יְהוָה חִלְּקָם

“Yahweh”

Here, **The face of Yahweh** represents Yahweh’s presence and active attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh himself scattered them]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:16 (#2)

לֹא יוֹסִיף לְהַבִּיטָם

“he will not continue to”

By saying Yahweh will **not continue to look at them**, the writer means that Yahweh will no longer watch over or care for the priests and prophets he has scattered. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, while the pronoun **them** refers to the priests and prophets. Alternate translation: [he will no longer watch over them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 4:16 (#3)

פְּנֵי כֹהֲנִים לֹא נָשָׂאוּ

“the priests they did not”

The writer is using **The face of the priests they did not lift up** as a common expression of the culture to mean they did not show respect to the priests. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. The pronoun **they** in the phrases **they did not lift up** and **they did not show grace** refers to the people of the nations. Alternate translation: [They did not show respect to the priests] or [They did not honor the priests]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 4:16 (#4)

לֹ֣א חָנָ֑נוּ

“they did not show grace”

The writer is using **show grace** as a common expression meaning to show kindness or mercy. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they did not show them any mercy]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 4:17 (#1)

עֵינֵ֔ינוּ

“Our eyes”

In this verse, the writer shifts from speaking about the people of Jerusalem in the third person (as in verses 1–16) to speaking in the first-person plural, identifying himself with them. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could note this shift or make it natural in your language.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 4:17 (#2)

עודינה תִּכְלֶ֖ינָה עֵינֵ֑ינוּ אֶל

“Our eyes still ended {looking} for”

Here the writer is using **Our eyes** to represent the act of watching and hoping. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [We still grew weary looking for]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:17 (#3)

עֶזְרָתֵ֣נוּ הָ֠הֶבֶל

“our help—a vapor”

Here the writer is speaking of the help they hoped for as if it were **a vapor**, something that appears but quickly vanishes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our help was worthless] or [our help amounted to nothing]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:18 (#1)

צָדְד֥וּ צְעָדֵ֖ינוּ

“They hunted our steps”

Here the writer is speaking as if the enemies were hunters and the people of Judah were prey that they **hunted** and **our steps** represents the people’s movements and daily activities. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They tracked our every movement]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:18 (#2)

קָרַ֤ב קִצֵּ֙ינוּ֙ מָלְא֣וּ יָמֵ֔ינוּ כִּי־בָ֖א קִצֵּ֑ינוּ

“Our end drew near; our days are full, for our end had come”

Jeremiah uses three phrases that build on each other to express the same idea with increasing intensity. **Our end** represents the time of their destruction, and **our days** represents the time they had left. The first phrase says it was approaching, the second that their time had run out, and the third confirms it had arrived. If your language has a natural way to build this kind of repetition, use it. If not, you could combine these and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [The time of our destruction was at hand —our days had run out, for our end had finally come]

See: Poetry

Lamentations 4:19 (#1)

עַל־הֶ֣הָרִ֔ים & בַּמִּדְבָּ֖ר

“On the mountains”

The writer is referring to all places by naming two extremes, **On the mountains** and **in the wilderness**.

If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Everywhere, whether on the mountains ... in the wilderness]

See: Merism

Lamentations 4:20 (#1)

רְוּחַ אַפֵּינוּ

“The breath of”

Here the writer is speaking as if the king were **The breath of our nostrils**, that is, as essential to the people’s lives as breathing. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The one who was essential to our life]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:20 (#2)

נִלְכַּד בְּשִׁחִיתוֹתָם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נִלְכַּד בְּשִׁחִיתוֹתָם”

Here the writer is speaking as if the king were an animal **captured in their pits**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fell into the traps they set] or [the enemies captured him in their pits]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:20 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר אָמַרְנוּ בְּצִלּוֹ נִחְיֶה בַגּוֹיִם

“we said & we will live among the nations”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [of whom we said that we would live under his protection among the nations]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Lamentations 4:20 (#4)

בְּצִלּוֹ נִחְיֶה

“we will live”

Here the writer is speaking as if the king’s protection were a **shadow** that shelters from the heat. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Under his protection we will live]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:21 (#1)

שִׂישִׂי וְשִׂמְחִי בַּת־אֱדוֹם יוֹשֶׁבֶת בְּאֶרֶץ עוּץ

“Edom, dweller & Uz”

The writer is speaking to the people of Edom, who are not present. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about the judgment that will come on Edom as well. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to his own people about Edom. Alternate translation: [The people of Edom who live in the land of Uz may rejoice and be glad now]

See: Apostrophe

Lamentations 4:21 (#2)

שִׂישִׂי וְשִׂמְחִי בַּת־אֱדוֹם

“Edom”

The writer actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. He is not genuinely urging Edom to celebrate but is sarcastically warning that judgment is coming for them as well. If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You may be celebrating now, people of Edom]

See: Irony

Lamentations 4:21 (#3)

גַּם־עָלַיִךְ תַּעֲבָר־כּוֹס

“to you the cup”

Here the writer is speaking as if God’s judgment were a **cup** of wine being passed to Edom to drink. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will also judge you]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:21 (#4)

תִּשְׁכְּרִי וְתִתְעָרִי

“and will make yourself naked”

Here the writer is speaking as if experiencing God’s judgment were becoming **drunk** and the resulting

public humiliation were making **yourself naked**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will stagger under his judgment and will be exposed in your shame]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 4:22 (#1)

תַּם־עֲוֹנֵךְ בַּת־צִיּ֑וֹן

“Your iniquity & Zion”

As in 4:6, the word **iniquity** here could represent either the sin itself or the punishment for it. In this context, the sense is most likely that Zion’s **punishment** is complete—Yahweh has finished disciplining his people and will not send them into exile again. Alternate translation: [Your punishment is complete, daughter of Zion] or [You have finished serving your sentence, people of Zion]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 4:22 (#2)

פָּקַ֖ד עֲוֹנֵ֑ךְ

“your iniquity”

The writer is using **He will visit your iniquity** as a common expression of the culture to mean that Yahweh will punish Edom for their wrongdoing. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He will punish you for your iniquity] or [He will hold you accountable for your wrongdoing]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 4:22 (#3)

גִּלָּ֖ה עַל־חַטֹּאתָ֑יִךְ

“your”

Here the writer is speaking as if Edom’s sins were hidden things that Yahweh will **uncover** for all to see. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will expose your sins for all to see]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a communal prayer to Yahweh, cataloging the people’s suffering (vv. 1–18), affirming God’s eternal throne (v. 19), and closing with petitions and rhetorical questions (vv. 20–22). Unlike chapters 1–4, it is not an acrostic, though it retains 22 verses matching the Hebrew alphabet.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Inherited guilt

The community confesses that their fathers sinned and died, yet the current generation bears their iniquity (v. 7), reflecting communal covenant accountability.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Recurring synonymous parallelism

Many verses pair synonymous lines, requiring translators to preserve the parallel structure while keeping each line distinct.

Lamentations 5:1 (#1)

זְכֹר֤ יְהוָה֙ מֶֽה־הָיָ֣ה לָ֔נוּ הביט וּרְאֵ֖ה אֶת־חֶרְפָּתֵֽנוּ

“Remember, Yahweh, what has happened to us; look and see our reproach”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remember, Yahweh, what has happened to us; please look and see our reproach]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 5:1 (#2)

הביט וּרְאֵ֖ה

“look and see”

The terms **look** and **see** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [look carefully at]

See: Doublet

Lamentations 5:2 (#1)

נַחֲלָתֵ֣נוּ נֶהֶפְכָה לְזָרִ֔ים בָּתֵּ֖ינוּ לְנָכְרִֽים

“Our inheritance has been turned over to strangers & to foreigners”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Our inheritance and our houses have been taken from us and given to people who are not from our land]

See: Parallelism

Lamentations 5:3 (#1)

אִמֹּתֵינוּ כְּאַלְמָנוֹת

“our mothers {are} like widows”

The point of this comparison is that just as **widows** are without husbands to care for them, so are **our mothers** without anyone to support them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [our mothers have no one to support them]

See: Simile

Lamentations 5:4 (#1)

מֵימֵינוּ בְּכֶסֶף שָׁתִינוּ

“Our water”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of the words so that the subject comes before the object. Alternate translation: [We drink our water for silver]

See: Information Structure

Lamentations 5:5 (#1)

עַל צַוָּארֵנוּ נִרְדָּפְנוּ

“on our necks”

The writer is using **pursued on our necks** as a common expression of the culture to mean “our enemies chase us relentlessly and are close behind us.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We are chased relentlessly by our enemies]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 5:5 (#2)

לֹא

“and rest is not”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rest**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and we are not allowed to rest]

See: Abstract Nouns

Lamentations 5:6 (#1)

מִצְרַיִם נָתַנּוּ יָד

“We have given a hand to Egypt”

The writer is using **given a hand** as a common expression of the culture to mean “submitted” or “surrendered.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have submitted to Egypt]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 5:6 (#2)

אַשּׁוּר

“to} Assyria”

The implication is that the people also submitted to Assyria, just as they submitted to Egypt. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to Assyria also]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Lamentations 5:6 (#3)

מִצְרַיִם נָתַנּוּ יָד אַשּׁוּר לִשְׂבְּעַ לָחֶם

“We have given a hand to Egypt, {to} Assyria, to be satisfied {with} bread”

Here, **to be satisfied with bread** marks getting food as the goal or purpose of submitting to Egypt and Assyria. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Lamentations 5:7 (#1)

אינם

“they are no more”

The writer is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **they are no more**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [they have died]

See: Euphemism

Lamentations 5:7 (#2)

אנחנו עָוֹנֹתֵיהֶם סָבָלְנוּ

“and we, we bear their iniquities”

The pronoun **we** refers to the current generation of the people of Jerusalem, in contrast with their **fathers** who sinned and died. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and we, the current generation, bear their iniquities]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Lamentations 5:7 (#3)

אנחנו עָוֹנֹתֵיהֶם סָבָלְנוּ

“and we, we bear their iniquities”

The writer is speaking as if the consequences of sin were a physical burden that people **bear**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and we, we suffer the consequences of what they did wrong]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 5:8 (#1)

מִיָּדָם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִיָּדָם”

Here, **their hand** represents “their control.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from their control]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 5:9 (#1)

מִפְּנֵי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִפְּנֵי”

The writer is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly here and in verse 10. Alternate translation: [because of]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 5:9 (#2)

חֶרֶב הַמִּדְבָּר

“the sword of”

Here, **the sword of the wilderness** represents “the violent dangers in the wilderness.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the violent dangers of the wilderness]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 5:10 (#1)

עוֹרֵנוּ כְּתַנּוּר נִכְמָרוּ

“Our skin grows hot”

The point of this comparison is that just as **an oven** is extremely hot, so the people’s **skin** is burning with intense heat from fever. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Our skin burns as hot as an oven]

See: Simile

Lamentations 5:11 (#1)

עִנּוּ & נָשִׁים

“They violate women”

The writer is referring to sexual assault in a polite way by using the word **violate**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [They sexually assault women]

See: Euphemism

Lamentations 5:12 (#1)

פְּנֵי זְקֵנִים

“elders”

Here, **the faces of elders** represents the elders themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the elders themselves]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 5:14 (#1)

זְקֵנִים מִשַּׁעְרָם שָׁבָתוּ

“Elders”

Here, **the gate** represents the place where civic leaders gathered to make decisions and administer justice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alter-

nate translation: [Elders have ceased from making decisions]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 5:14 (#2)

זְקֵנִים֙ מִשַּׁ֣עַר שָׁבָ֔תוּ בַּחוּרִ֖ים

“Elders”

The writer is referring to all of the people by naming two major components, **Elders** and **young men**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Everyone has stopped gathering at the gates, all the people have withdrawn]

See: Merism

Lamentations 5:15 (#1)

לִבֵּ֑נוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבֵּ֑נוּ”

The writer is speaking of the people’s emotions as if they were located in the **heart**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our emotions]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 5:16 (#1)

נָפְלָ֖ה עֲטֶ֣רֶת רֹאשֵׁ֑נוּ

“The crown of & has fallen”

The writer is speaking of the people’s honor and dignity as if it were a **crown** that could fall from their head. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have lost our honor and dignity]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 5:16 (#2)

אֽוֹי־נָ֥א לָ֖נוּ

“Woe now to us”

The writer is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of grief and despair. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [We are now in great misery]

See: Exclamations

Lamentations 5:17 (#1)

הָיְתָ֥ה דָוֶ֖ה לִבֵּ֑נוּ

“has become sick”

The writer is speaking of the people’s grief as if their **heart** had become physically **sick**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our heart is filled with grief]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 5:19 (#1)

לְעוֹלָ֖ם תֵּשֵׁ֑ב

“forever”

The writer uses the word **sit** to speak of Yahweh’s rule as if he were a king on a throne. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [reign forever]

See: Metaphor

Lamentations 5:19 (#2)

כִּסְאֲךָ֖

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כִּסְאֲךָ֖”

Here, **your throne** represents “your royal authority.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your royal authority is]

See: Metonymy

Lamentations 5:19 (#3)

לְדֹ֥ר וָדֹֽר

“to generation and generation”

The writer is using **to generation and generation** as a common expression of the culture to mean “throughout every generation” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [throughout every generation]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 5:20 (#1)

לָ֣מָּה לָנֶ֗צַח תִּשְׁכָּחֵ֙נוּ֙ תַּֽעַזְבֵ֣נוּ לְאֹ֔רֶךְ יָמִֽים

“forever & for the length of days”

The writer is using the question form to express anguish over feeling abandoned by God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [Surely you have forgotten us forever, you have forsaken us for so long]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 5:20 (#2)

לְאֹ֥רֶךְ יָמִֽים

“for the length of days”

The writer is using **for the length of days** as a common expression of the culture to mean “for a long time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for a very long time]

See: Idiom

Lamentations 5:21 (#1)

הֲשִׁיבֵ֤נוּ יְהוָה֙ ׀ אֵלֶ֣יךָ וְנָשׁ֔וּבָה חַדֵּ֥שׁ יָמֵ֖ינוּ כְּקֶֽדֶם

“Return us to yourself, Yahweh, and let us return; renew our days as of old”

These phrases are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please bring us back to yourself, Yahweh, and please let us return; please make our days as they were in times past]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Lamentations 5:22 (#1)

כִּֽי־אִם־מָאֹ֥ס מְאַסְתָּ֖נוּ

“For have you rejecting”

The writer is using the question form to express fear and anguish about the possibility that God has completely rejected his people. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [For you have completely rejected us! You have been angry against us beyond measure!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Lamentations 5:22 (#2)

מָאֹ֥ס מְאַסְתָּ֖נוּ

“have you rejecting”

The writer is repeating forms of the verb **rejected** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [have you rejected, yes, rejected us]

See: Reduplication

Lamentations 5:22 (#3)

עַד־מְאֹֽד

“beyond measure”

The writer says **beyond measure** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [so greatly]

See: Hyperbole